Explaining Can be Risky: The Effects of Justifications on Public Support for Politicians and Their Agenda

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Abstract

Politicians routinely use justifications to explain their policy choices, yet we know little about when and how these justifications influence public opinion. We argue that a justification's effect is the net valence of impressions created by two distinct signals: the act of justifying and the justification's content. We disentangle these signals through an automated analysis of party manifestos and two survey experiments (N $\approx$ 6,400) in Germany and the United Kingdom. Relative to an explicit refusal to justify, justifications raise support for both policies and politicians; but measured against the neutral baseline of mere endorsement, justifications fail to improve public opinion. Content effects are conditional on the audience's prior support for the invoked reason, and asymmetric, with smaller gains concentrated among liked groups and values and larger losses among disliked ones. Both account satisfaction and perceived policy benefit mediate these effects. Justification emerges not as a uniformly persuasive practice but as a conditional one: politicians may benefit from avoiding the penalty associated with refusing to explain, yet risk backlash when the reasons they provide conflict with their audiences' preferences. More broadly, the findings challenge the view of justification as an inherently beneficial form of political communication and suggest that its effects depend on both the expectations surrounding explanation and the content of the reasons offered.

Keywords: Justifications, Public Opinion, Political Communication, Explaining, Experiment, Text Analysis

Introduction

Justifications are statements in which politicians invoke normative reasons to explain why they endorse a policy (Bennett 1980; McGraw 2002). They are the most widespread argument to explain policy preferences (Willey 2002; Fenno 1978; Kittel and Vössing 2024; Steiner et al. 2004) and the most effective in shaping public opinion (Fine Licht et al. 2022; Grose et al. 2015; Marietta 2009; McGraw 1991; Robison 2024), but existing research has not yet shown why and how justifications work.

This article offers a theory and empirical analysis of justifications and their impact on public opinion. We argue that the effects of justifications result from the net valence of two distinct impression-formation processes: a generally positive impression from the act of justifying and a variable impression from justification content (the invoked reason). Politicians trying to mobilize support for themselves and their policy agenda through justifications stand to gain support from using popular content, but they also run the risk of offsetting the positive impression created by the act of justifying when the reasons they invoke are unpopular. Justifications thus operate through two components—whether politicians explain at all and what reasons they invoke—and their effects depend on how these components combine.

First, we argue that justifying a policy should provide a stable source of positive impressions resulting in greater support for politicians and their agenda by satisfying the social norm that potentially controversial behavior ought to be explained (Boltanski and Thévenot 2006; Schönbach 1990; Scott and Lyman 1968) and the democratic norm that politicians should explain themselves to be accountable to their voters (Bühlmann and Kriesi 2013; Robison 2024; Schedler 1999). However, existing research has never compared justifications to both non-justification options within a single study. Prior studies investigate either the explicit "refusal to justify" (Vössing 2023) or "mere endorsement," the statement of a policy position without justification (Esaiasson et al. 2017; Fine Licht et al. 2022; Gerber et al. 2014; Levendusky and Horowitz 2012; Robison 2017; Westwood 2015). We argue that the positivity of the act of justifying depends on the non-justification against which it is evaluated. Refusing to justify is the most blatant violation of the social and political norms of explaining. It should therefore cause more negative impressions and impose greater costs on public opinion than mere endorsement, making the apparent benefits of justifying larger when it is compared with a refusal to justify.

Second, we argue that the normative reasons for policy choices that can be invoked in justifications include group interests ("the policy is good for workers") and values ("the policy advances economic freedom"). Prior studies investigate the effects of groups (Aarøe and Petersen 2014; Arceneaux and Kolodny 2009; Bos et al. 2020; Huber et al. 2024; Huber and Haselmayer 2024; Thau 2021; Dassonneville et al. 2025) or values (Blumenau and Lauderdale 2024; Clifford 2019; Marietta 2009; McGraw 1991; Robison 2017) but not both at the same time. We analyze both categories and a wide range of specific reasons to broaden the scope and strengthen the reliability of conclusions about justification content. We argue that the effectiveness of a justification depends on whether voters support the norm it invokes, so that the content of justifications creates heterogeneous impressions depending on voters' prior views (Grose et al. 2015; Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Marietta 2009; Peterson and Simonovits 2017; Vössing

2021; Dassonneville et al. 2025).

We disentangle the two components of justifications—the act of justifying and justification content—and test our theoretical expectations using an automated text analysis and two preregistered survey experiments in Germany and the United Kingdom (N $\approx$ 6,400). The text analysis identifies—for use in the subsequent experiments—the most popular reasons politicians invoke in their justifications. Politicians use justifications to pursue two objectives—improving their reputation and raising support for their policy agenda (Strom 1990). The statements they deliver convey signals that are useful for evaluating politicians and their policy positions, and our experiments analyze the effects of justifications on both outcomes.

Our analyses yield four main findings that extend existing research in several ways. First, relative to the refusal to justify, both group and value justifications increase support for politicians and their policies. However, further analysis reveals that justifications do not consistently increase public support when compared with mere endorsement. Our research thus shows that much of the observed "justification effect" in prior work is driven by the cost of refusing to justify rather than a uniform benefit of providing reasons. Second, justifying can even reduce policy support compared to mere endorsement, and while not reducing politician support, justifying improves it less relative to mere endorsement than relative to a refusal to justify. This suggests that politicians can use mere endorsement in certain situations to substitute for justification, highlighting the importance of accountability cues that make the absence of an explanation salient.

Third, the effect of justification content is strongly conditional on audience evaluations of the invoked norm. Justifications invoking liked groups or values increase support, whereas those invoking disliked norms have weaker or negative effects. These effects of justifications are asymmetric, with small gains from liked content and large losses from disliked content, often large enough to offset or reverse the benefits of the act of justifying. Fourth, we theorize and provide empirical evidence for the two mechanisms through which justifications shape public opinion: perceived satisfaction with the explanation and perceived policy benefit. Justifications increase both, and both strongly predict policy and politician support. Mediation analyses show that these mechanisms account for a substantial share of the total effect of justifications. These mechanisms, and the effects they mediate, operate similarly for groups and values: voters make no distinction between the two types of content when processing justifications.

Taken together, the results suggest that the effects of justifications depend on both whether politicians explain their choices and the reasons they invoke. This has important implications for research on political communication and democratic accountability. Justification is not uniformly beneficial, but can protect politicians from the costs of refusing to explain while simultaneously exposing them to content-based backlash. Politicians therefore face a strategic trade-off: the benefits of explaining depend on whether the absence of an explanation is salient and whether audiences view the reasons invoked as desirable. More broadly, these findings challenge the view of justification as an inherently positive practice and highlight the importance of both communication context and audience predispositions in shaping its consequences.

A Theory of Justifications and Public Opinion

Justifications portray a policy as desirable and claim that its positive connection with a cherished norm is why it should be endorsed. This defines the justification as a political argument with a unique functional form, that is, a specific structure of rhetorical elements and connections between them: it makes a claim about the justifier's desirable behavior, gives a normative reason for the behavior, and establishes a positive connection between justifying reason and justified behavior (Vössing 2020). For example, a politician uses a policy justification when she says that she endorses raising the pension age (desirable policy-related behavior) because the policy leads to more fairness (normative reason). Political arguments in general are less constrained: they require only that a claim is made and a reason is given (Eemeren and Grootendorst 2004; Toulmin 2003). For instance, "the minimum wage will be raised because most members of parliament supported the policy and the prime minister opposing it has not paid enough attention" is an argument using the rhetorical element of "personal attack." It is not a justification because it does not make a claim about the speaker's behavior, does not invoke a normative reason, and does not establish a positive connection between a claim and a reason.

The functional form of the justification constrains it to one kind of rhetorical element—pointing out "beneficial behavior" by establishing a positive connection between a desirable norm and a desirable action. Prior research has studied variation in rhetorical elements (e.g., personal attack, appeal to history, side effect) independent of functional form (Blumenau and Lauderdale 2024) or different functional forms (e.g., excuses and justifications) with the rhetorical elements they require (McGraw 1991). By focusing on the justification, we hold both functional form and rhetorical element constant, to isolate the relative effects of the act of justifying and variation in justification content. We next develop the theoretical argument that these two components shape public opinion by creating impressions, which voters transfer to judgments of the politician giving the justification and the policy being justified.[1]

The Act of Justifying

The first signal conveyed by a justification is the act of justifying. The act of justifying a policy creates a positive impression by satisfying voters' expectation that politicians conform to social and democratic norms requiring them to explain their actions. To begin with, in social interactions, people expect others to explain their behavior when it deviates from the typical course of action or when it is potentially controversial (Scott and Lyman 1968). Explaining may

[1] We identified the preregistered hypotheses discussed in this section in italics. The preregistration (reproduced in Online Appendix, Section 3) covers several topics that are examined in separate papers. This paper tests the hypotheses concerning direct effects on policy support, direct effects on politician support, as well as mediation and mechanisms. We also consolidated closely related preregistered hypotheses where appropriate. For example, the separate hypotheses that justifying a policy increases policy support and politician support are reported here as a single hypothesis covering both outcomes.

be a vehicle of conflict resolution (Schönbach 1990) or an insincere script concealing important problems and preventing solutions (Edelman 1977). However, irrespective of whether the "true" function of an explanation is constructive or harmful, the expectation that people should explain their actions constitutes a deeply held social norm. Politicians who conform to this norm should therefore create more positive impressions among voters.

In addition to their status as a general social norm, explanations in democratic discourse also satisfy a specifically political expectation. Voters expect politicians to be accountable for their actions. One important aspect of accountability is voters' entitlement to receive and politicians' obligation to deliver explanations (Schedler 1999). By providing information about political actions and motivating reasons, justifications allow voters to determine whether politicians take their obligation to explain seriously, whether politicians have taken actions that voters want for reasons they appreciate, and whether policies are worth supporting. The act of justifying conveys a signal about politicians' willingness to conform to social and political expectations that provides readily actionable information for voters' judgments of the politician. The same act informs policy support by signalling to voters that the policy has been endorsed and justified by a relevant public figure. As a result, we expect that *justifying a policy raises policy support and politician support* (H 1).

The impressions created by exposure to justifications make essential contributions to the stock of considerations voters use when they reward or punish politicians and their policy agenda. This makes explaining a critical component of accountability, and accountability through explanations an essential part of representative democracy (Bovens 2010; Bühlmann and Kriesi 2013; Esaiasson et al. 2017; Fine Licht et al. 2022). Empirical analysis shows that voters consistently rank explaining of political decisions as one of the most important features of democracy (Ferrín and Kriesi 2016; Hernández 2016) and that explaining improves public satisfaction with democracy and the government (Robison 2024).

Not everyone likes every group and every value equally, but advancing group interests and promoting values are accepted as generally desirable norms in democratic politics. Justifications invoking these norms satisfy the social and political expectation that politicians ought to explain themselves: they establish accountability for a policy outcome by detailing a politician's role in it, by explicitly stating adequate motives (supporting values or group interests) and by accepting responsibility for policy-making through a focus on the decision-makers' sphere of influence. In contrast to justifications, excuses concede that a policy is not desirable (Austin 1956; Aytaç 2021; Bennett 1980; McGraw 1991, 2002; Scott and Lyman 1968). They claim that an unfortunate circumstance explains why an undesirable policy had to be supported. Like justifications, excuses explain individual behavior—they are the second of two types of political accounts besides the justification (Bennett 1980; McGraw 2002)—but other than justifications, they shift responsibility to external forces.

Distinct from both justifications and excuses, politicians engaged in blaming explain not their own actions but instead the policy itself and how someone or something else made it happen (Bach and Wegrich 2019; Hinterleitner 2020; Hood 2011; Kumlin 2011; Mortensen 2012; Poullikka 2024; Schlipphak et al. 2022; Schönhage et al. 2023; Traber et al. 2020; Weaver 1986).

For instance, "this harmful policy was adopted because of pressure from the European Union" is an act of blaming. It shifts responsibility even further away from politicians than excuses by explaining how an external actor caused a policy outcome. By contrast, justifications explain own behavior and invoke normative reasons in connection to the behavior. These attributes make justifications ideally suited to satisfy expectations about the social and political norms of explaining, which creates positive impressions and then increased public support for politicians and their policy agenda.

The positivity of the act of justifying depends on the non-justification to which it is compared. A non-justification yields larger estimates of the effects of justifying on public opinion the more negatively it is perceived. Prior research has compared justifying to either one of the two most important non-justifications available to politicians: "mere endorsement" (Esaiasson et al. 2017; Fine Licht et al. 2022; Gerber et al. 2014; Levendusky and Horowitz 2012; Robison 2017; Westwood 2015) or the "refusal to justify" (Vössing 2023). "Mere endorsement" means to express a policy position without justifying it (Broockman and Butler 2017; Grose et al. 2015): the justification is simply omitted and the omission is not mentioned. By contrast, "refusal to justify" means to actively and explicitly communicate to voters that the politician is not offering a justification.

When politicians engage in "mere endorsement," they do not draw attention to the fact that they fail to provide an explanation, whereas "refusal to justify" explicitly highlights the politician's failure to explain. This is why refusing to justify represents the more apparent and more egregious violation of the social and political norms stipulating that politicians ought to explain themselves. "Refusal to justify" constitutes an explicit rejection of the politician's perceived obligation. It signals disregard for voters' legitimate expectations. "Mere endorsement," by contrast, conveys no comparably negative signal because voters are not actively reminded that the politician expressing a policy position is violating any expectations. This is why we propose that *refusing to justify a policy preference (compared to simply not offering a justification) reduces support for the policy and the justifying politician* (H 2).

The Content of Justifications

The second signal conveyed by a justification comes from its content—the reason politicians invoke to justify their behavior. While the effect of the act of justifying (compared to a certain non-justification) should be relatively stable and generally positive, the effect of its content should vary between voters, creating positive impressions for some and negative impressions for others. This explains why justifications are risky: the variable effect of the reasons invoked as justification content may be negative in the electorate or some targeted segment of it, potentially outweighing the positive effect of the act of justifying.

Prior studies analyzing political texts show that the two types of reasons commonly invoked in justifications and similar statements are groups (Bojar and Kriesi 2020; Dolinsky 2022; Haines et al. 2019; Hopkins et al. 2024; Huber and Haselmayer 2024; Thau 2024; Tromborg and Jensen 2024) and values (Atikcan and Hand 2024; Bos and Minihold 2022; Kinski and Ripoll Servent 2022; Kraft and Klemmensen 2023; Maia et al. 2020; Marietta 2009; Wilde 2019). We argue that

in addition to being empirically ubiquitous, justifications invoking groups and values are also conceptually comprehensive. They constitute the two existing types of *partial justifications*. In this class of political argument, invoking one reason means selecting a subset of a broader category (groups or values) and positioning it against other reasons within that category. For instance, a politician saying that increasing the minimum wage strengthens independence is picking one of ten "basic values" (Schwartz 1992, 2006) at the expense of nine others. Politicians saying that cutting pensions is good for business owners are picking one of many groups affected by the policy.

Universal justifications, by contrast, invoke reasons that are presented as broadly applicable. Instead of selecting from a range of competing policy gains, universal justifications claim that a policy has broadly positive consequences. For instance, politicians saying that a policy advances the common good are making a universal claim about the policy's benefits. Universal justifications invoke generally desirable yet vague policy consequences that are unlikely to swing public opinion in any particular direction, whereas partial justifications can be expected to create variation. Partial justifications are the essential argument politicians use to explain their behavior in competitive democracies and the only category of justification expected to produce variable effects on public opinion.

Existing research has shown that groups and values influence public opinion when they are used in justifications and similar statements. First, studies in which political actors speak *to groups* show that identity primes (Bos et al. 2020; Howe et al. 2022; Klar 2013), appeals to groups (Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Thau 2021; Valenzuela and Michelson 2016; Dassonneville et al. 2025), policy statements catering to groups (Haffert et al. 2024; Kam et al. 2017; Robison et al. 2021), and messages targeting ingroup entitativity (Castano et al. 2002; Rydell and McConnell 2005) shape opinions among both group members and outsiders. Studies in which political actors speak *about groups* show that deservingness cues (Hansen 2019; Petersen et al. 2011; Slothuus 2007), racial and ethnic cues (Naumann et al. 2024; Sirin et al. 2016; Valentino et al. 2002), messages targeting outgroup entitativity (Castano et al. 2003), and appeals about groups (Finseraas et al. 2025; Huber et al. 2024; Schleiter et al. 2021) influence opinions. Second, prior studies have also shown that values shape opinions when invoked in justifications (Duell et al. 2022; Marietta 2008; McGraw 1998; Robison 2017; Sigelman et al. 1992; Vössing 2021), and when used as primes (Clifford et al. 2015; Feinberg and Willer 2013; Roccas et al. 2010), frames (Bayes et al. 2020; Feinberg and Willer 2019; Nelson 2015; Simonsen and Bonikowski 2022), or appeals (Brady et al. 2020; Jung 2020; Lipsitz 2018).

We elaborate on existing research, which investigates either groups or values, by analyzing both norms as mutually substitutable forms of justification content. We argue that groups and values influence public opinion based on the same principle when one of them is invoked as a reason for justifying a policy. Politicians who claim that a policy advances the interests of a group or a certain value will improve public support for themselves and their policy—to the extent that voters like the group respectively the value that will allegedly be promoted by implementing the policy. When voters hear justifications invoking disliked groups or values, the effects on public opinion will be negative. We thus expect that *the greater the support for the norm (the specific value or group) invoked in the justification, the greater the support for the justified policy and the*

justifying politician (H 3). Policy justifications describe the achievement of a certain norm as a consequence of a policy. The more voters value the norm advanced by the policy, the more positively they should evaluate the policy that advances it and the politician who contributes to enacting it. The content of a justification informs voters that a politician stands for a desirable norm, more so the more someone likes the norm, thereby facilitating support for the politician, while also signalling that the policy itself has desirable consequences, thereby increasing policy support.

The communication of justification content that aligns with audience views is an intentional act of tailoring whenever politicians act with purpose based on the expectation that their statement will be well received because of its popularity. Such tailoring, or more broadly the appeal of content to an audience, can be effective in politics (Bayes et al. 2020; Broockman and Butler 2017; Grose et al. 2015; Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Peterson and Simonovits 2017; Vössing 2021). However, prior research about content in justifications and similar statements presents an empirical puzzle, as some studies find considerable effects of variation in content (McGraw 1991; Marietta 2008; Grose et al. 2015; Vössing 2021; Jacobs and Shapiro 2000), while other studies find only small or no effects (Broockman and Butler 2017; Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Peterson and Simonovits 2017; Guinaudeau et al. 2026). We resolve this puzzle by disentangling two components of justifications, which were often conflated in prior research: justification content (the reasons invoked) and the act of justifying (the non-justification against which it is compared).

Mechanisms

The act of justifying and the justification content are the two signals conveyed by a justification. They influence public support for the objects associated with the justification (politicians and their policies) through the impressions they create in the audience. We argue that voters form impressions from these two signals and translate their cumulative valence into corresponding levels of support for the justifying politician and the justified policy. The positivity or negativity prompted by exposure to a justification is captured by a certain level of satisfaction with the received justification, called "account satisfaction" in prior research (McGraw 1991; McGraw et al. 1995; Vössing 2023). If the process of cumulative impression formation works as we suggest, *the effects of justifications on public opinion are mediated by account satisfaction* (H 4). This expectation implies two related relationships in the proposed process: first, the act of justifying and positively regarded content should increase account satisfaction, whereas failure to justify and negatively regarded content decrease it; and second, greater account satisfaction increases support for the politician offering the justification and the justified policy.

Our expectation that account satisfaction mediates the effects of justifications on public opinion, and the model of cumulative impression formation underlying it, build on studies of persuasion through political accounts (McGraw 1991, 2002; McGraw et al. 1993; McGraw et al. 1995; Nelson 2024; Nelson and Garst 2005; Vössing 2020, 2021, 2023) as well as foundational work about political persuasion (Chen et al. 1999; Chen et al. 1996; McGuire 1985; Petty et al. 2005; Petty and Cacioppo 1986; Zaller 1992; Druckman 2022), political accounts (Austin 1956; Bennett 1980; Benoit 2024; McGraw 2002; Schlenker and Weigold 1992; Scott and Lyman 1968), and argument structure (Areni and Lutz 1988; Eemeren and Grootendorst 2004; Grice 1975; Petty and

Wegener 1991). Our model disaggregates political statements into their component parts and traces how these components, through the signals they convey, affect public opinion. To explain these effects, the model emphasizes the spontaneous, heuristic processing of information proposed by dual process theories (Chen et al. 1999; Kahneman 2011; Petty and Cacioppo 1986) and other models of persuasion (Druckman 2022; McGuire 1985; Zaller 1992) as a foundational route through which people form political attitudes.

We argue that impression formation through the combined effects of different justification components generally takes place in the same way, regardless of the type of justification content. Both values and group interests are norms that can be promoted by policies, and exposure to justifications invoking these norms influences public opinion through the same process, with account satisfaction acting as a mediator. We further probe the processes through which justifications influence public opinion by examining potential variation across different types of justification content. Groups and values are distinct categories of norms. It is possible—even when they both influence opinions through the impressions they create in voters—that they generate these impressions and their downstream effects in different ways that reflect their unique attributes.

Any variation in processes of impression formation between group-based and value-based justifications should then stem from categorical differences between the two norms. Both types of justifications make claims about positive policy effects by suggesting that a group or a value will be promoted by a policy, but only the reference to group interests suggests tangible personal benefits, while the alleged policy effects on values remain intangible. Voters may form impressions and opinions in different ways because of the tangibility of policy benefits characteristic of group justifications and the intangibility characteristic of value-based justifications. Intangible policy consequences have a larger scope and apply with fewer restrictions than tangible policy consequences, but they are more remote, that is, less accessible to personal experience. Tangible policy consequences, by contrast, are more constrained in scope yet more proximate, and thus easier to experience.

Given the greater tangibility of group-based justifications, voters exposed to this type of justification may be more likely to think about the personal benefits associated with the policy. As a result, perceived personal benefits from a policy should play a greater role in forming impressions of the policy and the politician who endorsed it when voters hears a group-based rather than a value-based justification. If this is the case, then *the effects of group justifications on public opinion are mediated by perceived (personal) benefits from the policy*, whereas *the effects of value justifications on public opinion are not mediated by perceived benefits* (H 5).

Data and Method

We test our hypotheses using two survey experiments conducted with representative samples of voters in Germany and the United Kingdom (N $\approx$ 6,400). In each experiment, participants read statements in which politicians endorse a social policy and then either justify the endorsement—by invoking a social group or a value—or do not provide a justification. The content of justifications

is drawn from actual party communication: each experiment is preceded by an automated text analysis that identifies the groups and values that parties most commonly invoke when endorsing social policies. We therefore describe the text analyses first and then turn to the experiments they inform.

Automated Text Analysis to Identify Groups and Values

We conducted an empirical analysis of party manifestos to identify the groups and values politicians invoke most to justify the social policies they endorse. First, using text data and policy codes from the Comparative Manifesto Project (Volkens et al. 2021), we selected all sections of party manifestos in which political parties in Germany (1998–2021) and the United Kingdom (2015–2019) address social policy. We used all country-years for which data were available. Second, in the compiled text corpus, we identified statements in which parties endorse social policies using a dictionary of terms for demands, views, and actions, the three kinds of behavior through which a policy can be endorsed (see Online Appendix, Section 5.4).

Third, we detected the values and groups that are mentioned in a radius of two quasi-sentences around each endorsed policy. This decision reflects prior research in linguistics showing that people recall around four sentences from short-term memory (Gilchrist et al. 2008) and are able to reiterate around three to four sentences from a party manifesto (Noort et al. 2008). In the first text analysis, we identified groups with a dictionary of social groups based on Thau (2019) for the English texts as well as a translated and adapted German version (see Online Appendix, Sections 5.1 and 5.3). We identified values with English (Frimer 2020) and German (Bos and Minihold 2022) versions of the moral foundations dictionary (see Online Appendix, Section 5.1). This approach identified the three groups—children, workers, pensioners—and the three values—compassion, loyalty, fairness—that parties most frequently invoked in justifying social policies. We selected these groups and values as the justification content for the first experiment based on their average frequency rank across the two countries. This procedure ensured that the experimental treatments reflected commonly used political appeals while remaining comparable across countries.

We conducted additional text analysis using the same data and procedure to identify a structured a broader and more systematically structured set of groups and values for the second experiment. First, we identified the twelve most frequently communicated groups, ensuring that the three categories of groups were represented equally. The resulting categories and groups included universally deserving groups (children, pensioners, families, young people), traditional cleavage groups (workers, business owners, the self-employed, the unemployed), and new identity groups (migrants, rural people, urban people, as well as homosexual, bisexual, and transgender people).

We also identified the twelve most frequently used values across three established approaches to value classification. These included the four most popular moral foundations (Graham et al. 2013; Graham et al. 2009) already used for the first study, the four political values represented by the cells in a conventional two-dimensional political space (Hooghe et al. 2002; Kriesi et al. 2006) and the four most popular basic values (Schwartz 1992, 2006). We identified basic values using an established dictionary (Ponizovskiy et al. 2020) for the English text data and a translated

German version (see Online Appendix, Section 3.4). Moral foundations and basic values are the two most developed and widely used approaches to theorizing and categorizing human values. The resulting set comprised four moral foundations (compassion, fairness, loyalty, authority), four basic values (kindness, merit, security, independence) and four political values (economic coordination, economic freedom, traditional values, personal freedom).

The text analyses reveal substantial similarity in the groups and values invoked by political parties in Germany and the United Kingdom, alongside several country-specific patterns (see Online Appendix, Section 6 for full results). Pensioners and workers, for example, are among the three most frequently mentioned groups in both countries. At the same time, German parties refer particularly often to children, whereas UK parties make more frequent references to unions and professional groups such as teachers and public servants. These differences become clearer when groups are classified into the categories used in the second experiment: the main cross-national difference is the greater emphasis German parties place on universally deserving groups and UK parties place on economic cleavage groups. Identity-related groups, by contrast, receive relatively little attention in party manifestos despite the growing importance of identity in political judgments. References to migrants and asylum seekers are most common in both countries, but the remaining patterns differ substantially: German parties make relatively more references to homosexual, bisexual, and transgender people, whereas UK parties refer more frequently to rural and urban people.

The same pattern observed for group references—substantial consistency between the two countries alongside some notable differences—also emerges in the use of values (see Online Appendix, Section 6). First, although the rank order of the moral foundations differs across countries, the four most frequently invoked foundations are the same. Compassion is the most frequently invoked moral foundation in both countries, while purity and authority are the least frequently invoked. The basic values included in the second study show a similar pattern of cross-national consistency. Merit, independence, and kindness are the three most frequently invoked values overall. For the fourth value, we selected security over conformity, power, and universalism because it provides greater variation in value content and ranks among the three most frequently invoked values in the UK, whereas power and universalism do not rank among the top three in either country (see Online Appendix, Section 6.4).

Survey Experiments

Based on the results of our text analysis, we conducted two survey experiments. The first study was preregistred and fielded in October 2023 in Germany and the United Kingdom ($N = 1,400$ per country), with samples stratified to match population distributions of each country on age, education, gender, and region. Participants in the first experiment were randomly assigned to receive a "group justification," a "value justification," or a "refusal to justify."[2]

[2] A fourth group received a combined justification invoking both a group and a value; its effects are similar to those of single-appeal justifications on both outcomes (see Online Appendix, Section 7, Figure A1).

After giving informed consent and completing pre-treatment questions, participants read six randomly selected statements adapted from a voting advice application (VAA).[3] Each statement featured a hypothetical politician endorsing a social policy in a verbatim quote. We held the direction of the endorsement constant while varying policy type across the major areas of social policy: health, labor relations, digital work, pensions, education, and socio-ecological transformation (see Online Appendix, Section 2.3). In the group-justification condition, explained the policy by referring to the interests of a randomly selected group (children, workers, or pensioners); in the value-justification condition, the politician invoked a randomly selected value (compassion, loyalty, or fairness); and in the refusal condition, the politician "offered no explanation". The vignette was repeated six times, once per policy. Policy order and treatment assignment were randomized independently for each participant. After each statement, participants rated their support for the policy and the endorsing politician on 0–100 thermometer scales. We then collected socio-demographic characteristics and measures of political sophistication. The study closes with an extensive debriefing.

The second experiment was preregistered and fielded in May 2024 in Germany and the United Kingdom (N = 1,760 per country), using samples representative of each country's population in terms of age, education, gender, and region. It retains the same protocol with three changes designed to replicate and extend the first experiment. First, it drew justification content from the larger and more structured set of groups and values identified in the second text analysis, permitting a more detailed test of the effects found in Study 1. Second, it distinguished between two forms of non-justification: the original refusal to justify and a new "mere endorsement," in which the politician endorsed the policy without further comment. Third, it added four policies—regional equality, Europeanization of social policy, levelling, and infrastructure investment—bringing the total to ten policies (see Online Appendix, Section 2.3 for details).

Methodological Considerations

We take several measures to improve the validity and the real-world relevance of our experimental treatments and estimates. First, we leverage two representative samples from different countries with varying institutions and patterns of political conflict, a range of policies, and diverse justification content to understand the implications of individual-level processes for political communication, democratic competition, and public policy debates. Our focus on a specific policy field (social policy) allows us to analyze justifications and their effects comprehensively within clearly defined boundaries. At the same time, social policy can be understood as an example of conflict over a relevant and controversial, but not acutely polarized, issues, providing a useful setting for assessing whether our findings extend beyond any single policy dispute.

Second, we systematically vary attributes of our treatments' to minimise potential artifacts and isolate the effects of interest. To begin with, in each statement, we randomly vary the name of the politician endorsing the policy. We use female and male names common in the country's largest

[3]The statements were submitted by politicians considering a run for parliament at the request of the non-partisan organization administering the VAA. See Online Appendix, Section 1.1, for further details.

ethnic group, pre-tested among native speakers for commonness and neutrality (see Online Appendix, Sections 1.4 and 2.4). We also randomize the party affiliation of our hypothetical politicians among the largest parties represented in each country's parliament at the time: Conservatives and Labour for the United Kingdom, and SPD (Social Democrats), CDU (Christian Democrats), and Greens (eco-left-libertarian) in Germany.

Third, we vary the wording of the connection between policy-related behavior and justifying norm to ensure that our estimates are not artifacts of a particular type of semantic connection. In the first study, we randomly vary three options: one in which the politician endorses the policy for its impact on a group or value ("this policy will have a positive impact and support workers/fairness"), a second in which the policy represents the value or group ("this policy stands for workers/fairness"), and a third in which the politician makes an appeal using the value or group after endorsing the policy ("we need to do more for fairness/workers"). In study 2, we use a generic formulation that encompasses the three previously used formulations of impact, representation, and appeal ("this policy supports workers/fairness").[4]

Fourth, we construct our treatments to pinpoint and isolate the effects of our theoretical constructs as cleanly as possible (see Online Appendix, Sections 1.2 and 2.2). We use single justifications rather than more extensive speech acts that may contain multiple arguments. In addition, the justifications are identical in wording except for the endorsed policy and the reasons invoked to justify it. Together with the randomized assignment of secondary attributes described above and the use of groups and values most common in actual party communication, this design allows us to estimate the effects of both the act of justifying and the content of justifications. The valid and reliable estimation of treatment effects is supported by an effective cover story. The cover story further supports the realism of this design: participants are told that politicians were asked to deliver their statements in a preconfigured format to facilitate comparisons across politicians. This makes the standardized and concise character of the treatments plausible while preserving their correspondence to the real-world communication processes we seek to study.

Analysis

The Act of Justifying

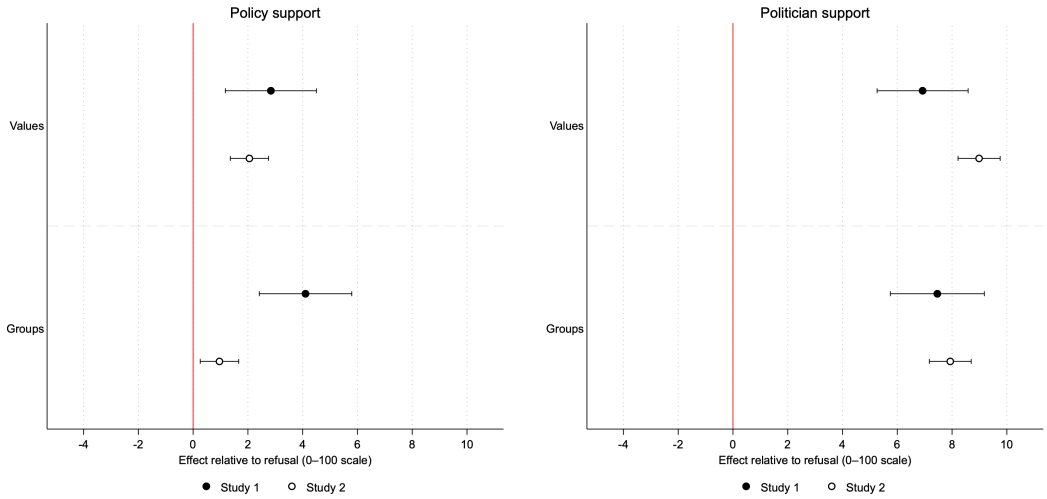
We begin by testing our first hypothesis (H 1), which predicts that justifying a policy raises policy support and politician support, with a linear regression model estimated separately within each study and pooled across countries. Because respondents evaluate multiple policies, we estimate models with respondent fixed effects, which absorb stable individual differences and identify treatment effects from within-respondent variation in the randomly assigned treatments. For respondent i evaluating statement j, we estimate

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha_i + \beta_1 \text{Value}_{ij} + \beta_2 \text{Group}_{ij} + \sum_p \gamma_p \text{Policy}_{ij}^p + \varepsilon_{ij}, \tag{1}$$

[4] See Online Appendix, Section 1.7 for further details

where Y_{ij} is support for the endorsed policy or the endorsing politician measured on a 0–100 scale, α_i are respondent fixed effects, Policy_{ij}^{p} are indicators for the endorsed policy, and standard errors are clustered by respondent. The omitted category is refusal to justify, so β_1 and β_2 estimate the effect of value or group justifications, respectively, relative to refusal to justify.

Figure 1: Effects of Justifying a Policy Endorsement on Policy and Politician Support

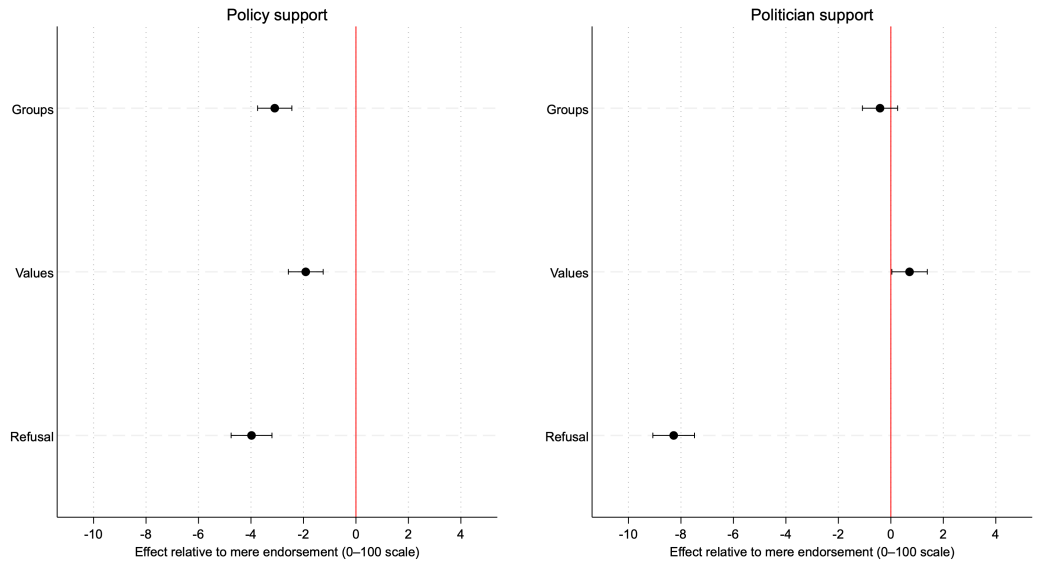


Note: Points report the estimated effect of group and value justifications, each relative to a refusal to justify, on support for the endorsed policy (left panel) and the endorsing politician (right panel), with 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are obtained from Equation 1, which includes respondent and policy fixed effects; countries are pooled, and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Higher values indicate greater support on a 0–100 scale. Filled markers indicate Study 1; hollow markers Study 2.

Figure 1 shows the estimates for the two studies. In Study 1, both justification types improve public opinion relative to refusal. A group justification increases policy support by 4.1 points and a value justification by 2.8 points; the corresponding effects on politician support are larger, at 7.5 and 6.9 points, all significant at conventional levels. Study 2, with a larger array of justification content and ten policies, replicates this pattern: justifications raise support for both the policy and the politician, with larger effects on politician support (group: $+7.9$; value: $+9.0$, both $p < 0.001$) than on policy support (group: $+1.0$, $p = 0.007$; value: $+2.1$, $p < 0.001$). The evidence from both studies is thus consistent with H 1. Relative to a politician who refuses to justify, offering either kind of justification raises support for both the policy and, more strongly, the politician. These results, however, cannot distinguish whether the advantage reflects a benefit of justifying, a penalty for refusing, or both.

Study 2 lets us distinguish the benefit of justifying from the cost of refusing to justify by adding the mere-endorsement condition, in which the politician endorses the policy without offering a justification or further comment. Our second hypothesis (H 2) predicts that refusing to justify has a more negative impact on public opinion than mere endorsement. To test H 2, we re-estimate Equation 1 using the Study 2 data, with mere endorsement as the reference category.

Figure 2: Effects of Justifying and of Refusing to Justify, Relative to Mere Endorsement



Note: Points report the estimated effects of a group justification, a value justification, and a refusal to justify, each relative to mere endorsement, on support for the endorsed policy (left panel) and the endorsing politician (right panel), with 95% confidence intervals. Estimates use respondent and policy fixed effects. Countries are pooled and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Higher values indicate greater support on a 0–100 scale.

Figure 2 refines our interpretation of H 1 and provides strong support H 2. When the reference point is mere endorsement rather than refusal, justifying a policy does not generally improve public opinion. The effect of a justification on politician support is small (group: -0.4, $p = 0.23$; value: $+0.7$, $p = 0.04$), while its effect on policy support is negative (group: -3.1; value: -1.9; both $p < 0.001$). The positive effects observed relative to refusal are therefore driven primarily by the penalty associated with not providing an explanation, rather than by a general benefit of justifying. Relative to mere endorsement, refusing to justify reduces policy support by 4.0 points and politician support by 8.3 points (both $p < 0.001$). These results support H 2 while refining the interpretation of H 1: politicians appear to benefit from explaining primarily because failing to explain is costly, rather than because providing a justification is itself rewarded.

These results do not imply that justifications are substantively inconsequential. Average effects can conceal meaningful variation in how different reasons are received. A justification may help when it invokes a group or value that voters support, but hurt when it invokes one they dislike. We therefore turn next to the content of justifications and test whether their effects vary with voters' evaluations of the groups and values they invoke.

Justification Content

The next question is whether the effects of justification depend on the norm it invokes. The average effects reported above may conceal substantial heterogeneity across different kinds of justifications. H 3 proposes that justifications are more effective when they invoke norms that the

audience supports. To test this, we classify each invoked group or value according to the respondent's thermometer rating of that norm on a 0–100 thermometer, distinguishing those rated above the scale midpoint from those rated below it.[5] These ratings are measured before the experiment.

We then estimate

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha_i + \sum_c \beta_c, \text{Condition}^c * ij + \sum_p \gamma_p \text{Policy}^p * ij + \varepsilon_{ij}, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{ij} is respondent i's evaluation in task j, Condition^c_{ij} indexes justification type crossed with whether the invoked norm is supported, α_i is a respondent fixed effect, and Policy^p_{ij} are policy-domain fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered by respondent. Refusal to justify is the reference category in both studies; in Study 2, mere endorsement provides an additional reference category for the corresponding comparisons.

Figure 3 shows that the effects of a justification depend on the norm it invokes. In Study 1, justifications referencing liked groups or values increased policy support relative to the refusal to justify, whereas justifications invoking disliked norms produced little or no change. The same pattern appears for evaluations of the politician: liked norms generated substantially larger gains in support than disliked ones. The positive effect of justification is thus concentrated among arguments grounded in norms that respondents favor.

Study 2 yields a similar pattern. Relative to mere endorsement, justifications invoking liked groups or values increase support for the politician, whereas disliked groups reduce it and disliked values have no discernible effect. For policy support, all justification types perform worse than mere endorsement, but justifications invoking liked norms consistently come closer to matching it than those invoking disliked norms. Across both studies, the more positively respondents view the invoked norm, the more favorable the response to the justification. In Study 2 this dependence is stronger for appeals to groups than for appeals to values.[6]

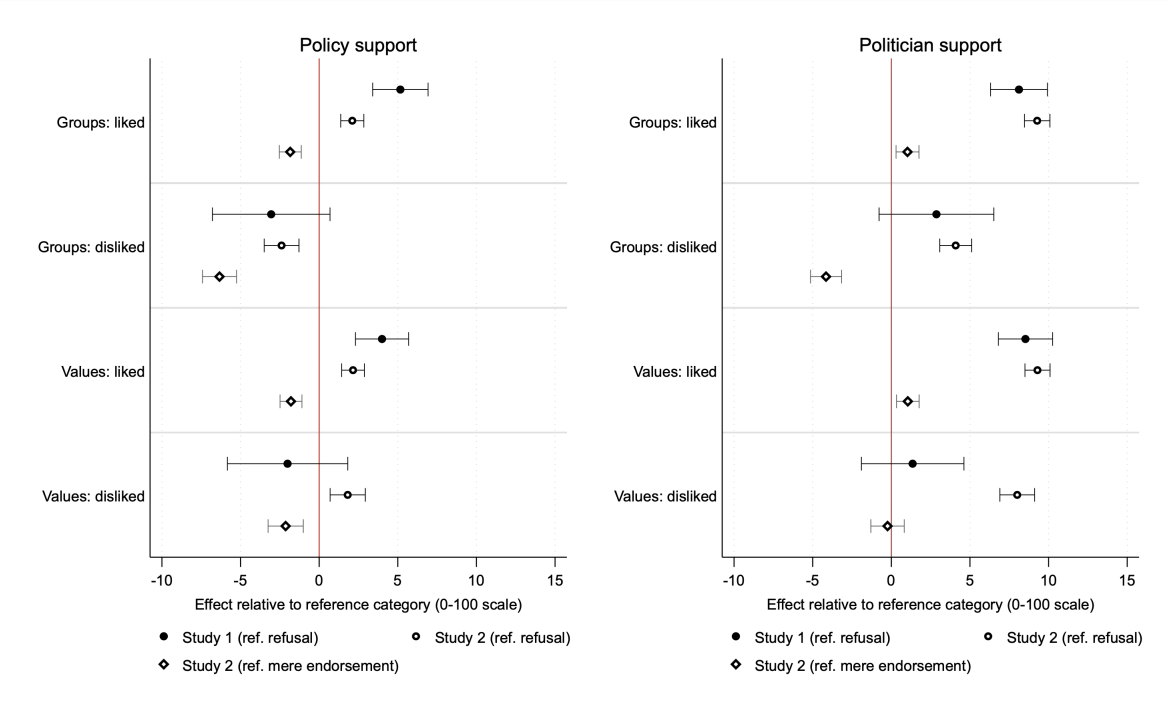
Overall, Figure 3 shows that relative to the refusal to justify, even disliked justifications can increase support because they avoid the penalty associated with offering no reason. Relative to mere endorsement, however, only justifications invoking liked norms improve evaluations. The value of justification therefore depends not simply on providing a reason, but on which reason is provided. Justifications increase support when they appeal to norms respondents like, but provide little benefit, and in some cases impose a penalty, when they invoke norms respondents reject. Averaged across a diverse set of groups and values, these opposing effects largely cancel out. The

[5] Respondents rating a group or value at exactly 50 are excluded, which removes roughly 2% of justification tasks. Results are substantively unchanged when the sample median is used as the cut instead (see Online Appendix, Section 3, Figure A2).

[6] The same asymmetry appears when support for the invoked norm is measured continuously. See Online Appendix, Section 7, Figure A3

next section explores the mechanisms through which justification content shapes public opinion.

Figure 3: Effects of Justifications by Support for the Invoked Norm



Note: Points report the estimated effects of group and value justifications that invoke either liked or disliked norms, with 95% confidence intervals. Effects are shown relative to the reference condition. Estimates use respondent and policy fixed effects. Countries are pooled and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Higher values indicate greater support on a 0–100 scale.

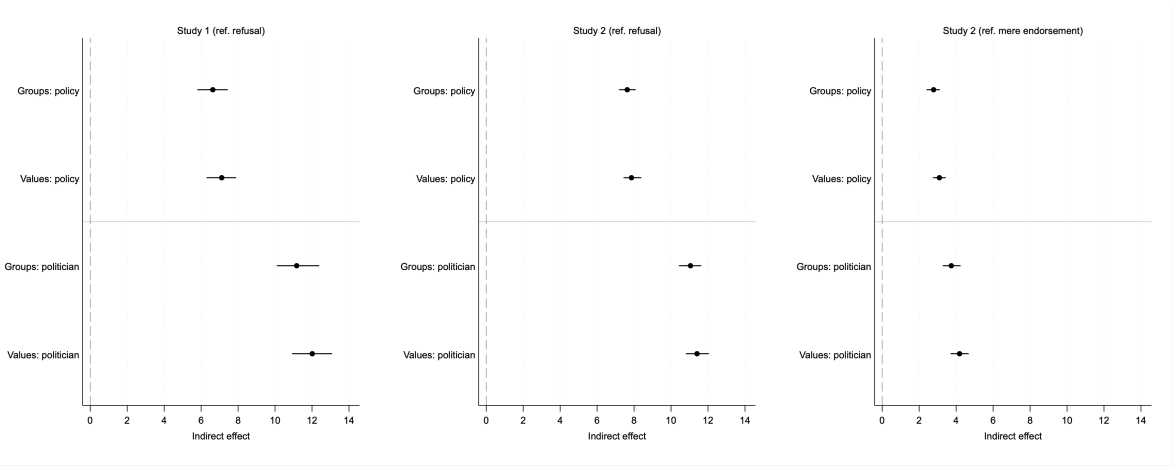
Mediation Analysis

Hypothesis 4 proposes that justifications shape political evaluations by influencing how respondents assess the account politicians provide. Specifically, we expect justifications to increase satisfaction with the account, which should, in turn, translate into more favorable evaluations of both the policy and the politician. Accordingly, the effects of justification type should be partially mediated by account satisfaction.

We assess this mechanism using mediation models with respondent fixed effects. For each outcome, we estimate the effect of justification type on account satisfaction (path a), the association between account satisfaction and the outcome, conditional on justification type (path b), and the remaining direct effect of justification type. The indirect effect is given by the product ab. Uncertainty is assessed using bias-corrected percentile confidence intervals based on a

respondent-level cluster bootstrap.[7]

Figure 4: Indirect Effects of Justifications through Account Satisfaction



Note: Points report estimated indirect effects of group and value justifications through account satisfaction on policy and politician support across Study 1 and Study 2. Whiskers indicate 95% bias-corrected percentile confidence intervals from a cluster bootstrap with respondent-level resampling and 2,000 replications.

Figure 4 presents the estimated indirect effects. In Study 1, where the reference category is refusal to justify, both justification types substantially raise account satisfaction, by 0.62 and 0.66 standard deviations for group and value justifications, respectively, and account satisfaction strongly predicts subsequent evaluations. The resulting indirect effects are 6.63 and 7.11 points for policy support and 11.17 and 12.02 points for politician evaluations. Study 2 shows a similar pattern relative to refusal, with indirect effects of 7.63 and 7.86 points for policy support and 11.05 and 11.41 points for politician evaluations. When comparing a politician who justifies with one who simply endorses the policy without explanation, the indirect effects fall by roughly two-thirds, to 2.78 and 3.10 points for policy support and 3.74 and 4.19 points for politician evaluations.[8] These results are consistent with Hypothesis 4: account satisfaction accounts for a substantial part of the relationship between justification type and political evaluations.

[7]Confidence intervals are based on 2,000 respondent-level bootstrap replications. Total, direct, and indirect effects are reported in Online Appendix, Section 7, Table A1.

[8]Several elements limit the causal interpretation of these estimates. First, account satisfaction is not randomized, so the indirect effects rest on the assumption that no unobserved factor confounds the relationship between the mediator and the outcome. Second, the mediator and the outcome measures appeared on a single screen, so their causal ordering is assumed on theoretical grounds. Third, account satisfaction correlates strongly with politician evaluations within respondents. We therefore treat the policy-support models as the primary test of H4 and report the politician-evaluation models as descriptive.

Finally, Hypothesis 5 proposes that group-based justifications shape political evaluations by increasing perceived personal benefits from the policy. Because group-based justifications make the beneficiaries of a policy more tangible, they may prompt respondents to think more readily about the personal benefits associated with the policy. These perceived benefits should, in turn, influence evaluations of both the policy and the politician who endorsed it.

We examine this using the same specification as for H4. For each outcome, we estimate the product of the effect of justification type on perceived benefit and the association between perceived benefit and the evaluation, conditional on justification type (ab), with respondent fixed effects and respondent-clustered bootstrap confidence intervals.[9]

The results shown in Figure 5 do not support H5. In Study 1, the pathway through perceived benefit is small for both justification types and not distinguishable from zero. In Study 2 the pathway is distinguishable from zero, but it runs against the prediction. Relative to a refusal to justify, the pathway is larger for value than for group justifications, at 0.99 versus 0.40 points on policy support and 0.88 versus 0.35 on politician evaluations. Relative to mere endorsement, both pathways turn negative and the group pathway is the more strongly so. Overall, the effects are small in magnitude. Perceived personal benefit therefore seems to account for a negligible share of how justifications shape political evaluations.[10]

Taken together, the two mechanisms account for different shares of the effect of justifications on political evaluations. Satisfaction with the account transmits a substantial portion in both studies and for both outcomes, whereas perceived personal benefit transmits almost none. Justifications thus appear to matter less for what they promise than for whether they are judged an adequate account at all.

Conclusion and Discussion

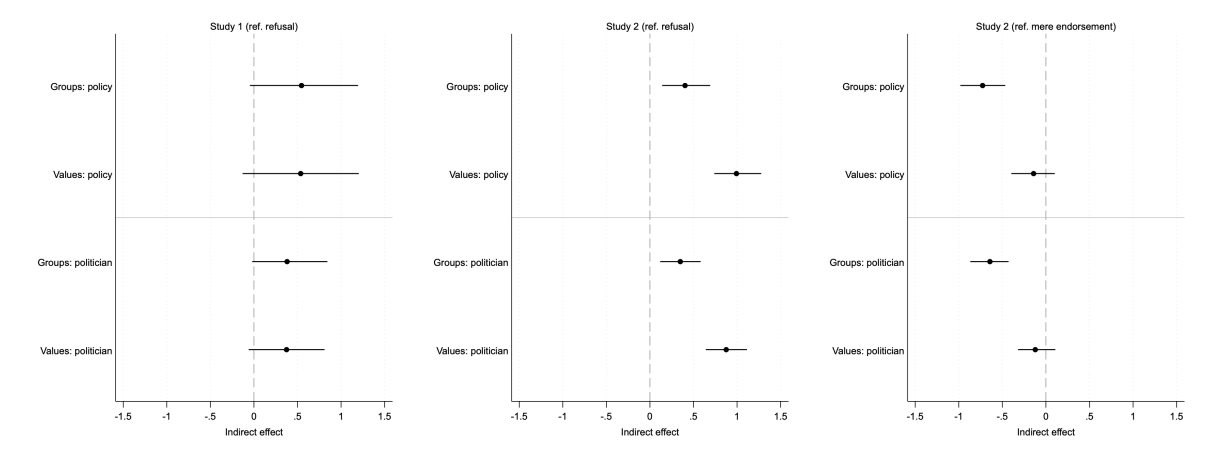
Politicians are expected to explain their policy choices, and existing research generally assumes the justifications they offer are persuasive. Yet, it remains unclear why justifications persuade and how consistently they do so. Although most studies find substantial effects of political justifications on public opinion (McGraw 1991; Marietta 2008; Grose et al. 2015; Vössing 2021; Jacobs and Shapiro 2000), others find more limited effects (Broockman and Butler 2017; Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Peterson and Simonovits 2017; Guinaudeau et al. 2026).

In this paper, we resolve the apparent contradiction in prior research by treating justifications not as single statements but as combinations of two signals: the act of justifying and the content of the justification. We argue that their effects depend on the net valence of impressions these signals

[9]The perceived-benefit item was administered after both outcome measures, so the causal ordering assumed by the mediation model is not established by the design. We use the standard terminology but treat these estimates as consistent with the proposed mechanism rather than as establishing it.

[10]Total, direct, and indirect effects are reported in Online Appendix, Section 7, Table A2.

Figure 5: Indirect Effects of Justifications through Perceived Policy Benefit



Note: Points report estimated indirect effects of group and value justifications through perceived policy benefit on policy and politician support across Study 1 and Study 2. Whiskers indicate 95% bias-corrected percentile confidence intervals from a cluster bootstrap with respondent-level resampling and 2,000 replications.

create in their audience. Building on this framework, we disentangle the two components of justifications in two preregistered experiments conducted in Germany and the United Kingdom. Our framework also provides a possible explanation for the divergent findings in prior research. Studies that focus on variation in justification content estimate the effect of one component of justification and may therefore overlook the contribution of the act of justifying itself. Moreover, because the effects of justification content are heterogeneous, average effects may appear modest even when particular forms of content have substantial effects. By contrast, studies that compare justifications with explicit non-justifications capture the combined effects of the act of justifying and its content.

Our analysis builds on the distinction between the act of justifying and justification content to analyze both the direct effects of justifications on public support and the mechanisms involved. First, we find that justifications raise support relative to an explicit refusal to justify, reproducing the positive estimates reported in prior work (Vössing 2023; Fine Licht et al. 2022; Robison 2024). However, this advantage nearly disappears when justifying is compared to mere endorsement: relative to a politician who simply states a position without explanation, justifications do not increase public support. This result reflects both the penalty respondents impose on politicians actively refusing to explain their decisions and the fact that the positive effect of justifying is highly conditional on the content of the justification. We show that much of the "justification effect" documented in prior work is the cost of refusal rather than a universal benefit of reason-giving. Moreover, the two most common non-justifications—mere endorsement and refusal—are not interchangeable: only conspicuous refusal is penalized, implying that accountability pressures emerge only when the absence of an explanation is made salient.

By analyzing groups and values within a common framework, we establish that justification

content is governed by an audience-dependent logic, that operates similarly across both types of norms. Justifications invoking groups or values favored by respondents raise support, whereas those invoking disliked norms have weak or negative effects. Averaged across a diverse set of reasons, these opposing impressions largely cancel. This asymmetry echoes a growing body of work on group-based appeals. Most recently, Guinaudeau et al. (2026) find that group-targeted campaign pledges do not outperform broad-based, universalistic ones, and that their net electoral effect is governed less by mobilizing intended beneficiaries than by alienating those who feel excluded. The same conditionality appears in the broader literature on group cues, where appeals help among sympathetic audiences but can backfire among others (Hersh and Schaffner 2013; Thau 2021; Huber et al. 2024). Our results extend this logic beyond electoral pledges and appeals to policy justifications, beyond vote intention to evaluations of both policies and politicians, and beyond groups alone to encompass values.

Second, the two mechanisms we examine contribute very unequally. Justifications shape opinion primarily by raising satisfaction with the account a politician provides; the pathway through perceived policy benefit is consistently small and, when justifying is compared with mere endorsement, runs in the opposite direction The finding that account satisfaction carries most of the effect of explaining is consistent with the model of cumulative impression formation developed in research on political accounts (Vössing 2023, 2021) and places the act of justifying within a broader normative expectation of accountability (Schedler 1999; Robison 2024). What matters, according to our evidence, is less what a justification promises than whether it is judged an adequate account in the first place.

The predicted asymmetry between group- and value-based appeals does not emerge. Perceived benefit is no more consequential for group-based justifications than for value-based ones, and in Study 2 the association is, if anything, stronger for the latter. This parallels the equivalence we observe in the direct effects of the two justification types. Variation across justifications appears to arise not from any categorical difference between appeals to groups and appeals to values, but from how individual respondents regard the particular groups and values invoked. Because the perceived-benefit measure followed both outcome measures in the instrument, so we cannot rule out that respondents inferred expected benefits from evaluations they had already formed. The estimates for this mechanism should therefore be interpreted as associations rather than causal indirect effects.

Citizens rely on individual views about justification content, together with the impressions formed through the act of justifying, to express opinions about both objects of judgment addressed by the justification—the justifying politician and the justified policy. The content of justifications signals that politicians are responsible for advancing a desirable norm through the policies they endorse. The act of justifying, in turn, signals that the politician conforms to expectations about democratic and social behavior and may enhance perceptions of the policy by associating it with a politician who meets those expectations. Justifications thus provide an immediate argumentative link to the politician and a more indirect link, through the politician's persona, to the policy. Their informational value may therefore be greater for evaluations of politicians than for evaluations of policies. This interpretation is consistent with our results, which show generally larger effects for politician support than for policy support, although evaluating this possibility more systematically

remains an important direction for future research.

More broadly, our results illustrate how the aggregate effect of a communicative act can conceal opposing processes and depend on the conditions under which it is received. The act of justifying and the content of the reason can generate countervailing effects, and their combined effect depends on the baseline against which justifying is judged and on the audience's prior attachment to the invoked norm. Normatively, this complicates the optimistic view that justification is an unambiguously beneficial democratic practice (Bühlmann and Kriesi 2013; Esaiasson et al. 2017; Fine Licht et al. 2022). Justification is rewarded mainly when its omission is made salient, while providing substantive reasons also exposes politicians to losses when those reasons invoke unpopular norms. Politicians therefore face a trade-off: when refusal is not salient, withholding an explanation may carry little cost, whereas the benefits of reason-giving depend on the popularity of the invoked norm.

Our study also has several limitations. Our treatments isolate the components of interest but abstract from the more complex appeals found in real campaigns. Our two-country scope, though spanning distinct institutional settings, leaves the generalizability of the patterns to other contexts open. Our mediation results, finally, rest on observational variation in the proposed mediators and the sequential-ignorability assumptions required by such designs; they are best read as consistent with the impression-formation account. Future work could reintroduce partisan cues to test whether source credibility dampens or amplifies content-based losses. Extending the analysis to behavioral outcomes and to the strategic calculations of politicians who decide whether and how to justify would further clarify when reason-giving mobilizes, alienates, or goes unnoticed.

Taken together, our results suggest a more measured view of justification in democratic politics. Reason-giving is not uniformly persuasive. Its value lies less in the provision of reasons per se than in avoiding the visible refusal to provide one and less in the act of explaining than in whether the reason offered resonates with what an audience already holds dear.

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Supplemental Online Appendix

"Explaining Can be Risky: The Effects of Justifications on Support for Politicians and Their Agenda"

Konstantin Vössing, Eva Krejcova, Agni Poullikka, and Diana Burlacu

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Appendix 1: Design First Experiment

Appendix 1.1: Text introducing the treatment section

Before exposure to the treatment section, participants read the following introductory text:

A voting advice application (VAA) is a website that collects information about the views and statements of politicians and political parties to help voters make informed vote choices.

The VAA relies on direct quotes from politicians and parties whenever possible, to make sure that the information it provides is accurate and unbiased. The team running the VAA takes information for the VAA from official party manifestos and from politicians' answers to a questionnaire.

We will now show you six policy statements from the VAA. They were given in response to the VAA questionnaire by politicians who are currently considering running for a seat in Parliament. In the statements, politicians talk about their views, their votes on different policies, and the reasons for their choices.

As a part of the questionnaire, the VAA team sends politicians a template with certain phrases and asks them to use it when giving answers. This is why some parts of the statements you are about to read will look quite similar. The VAA uses a template so that citizens can easily spot differences and compare politicians as effectively as possible.

Moreover, since we randomly selected the six statements, **the politicians you will read about can be quite different or quite similar in several ways**, such as their party affiliation or their gender.

Please read the statements carefully, and then answer a few questions about them.

Appendix 1.2: Setup of the treatment text

After the introductory text, participants read six treatment texts (one after another, each with one of six endorsed policies, in randomized order). Treatment assignment and measurement of dependent variables is conducted separately for each of the six treatment texts.

English version

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

NAME (PARTY): "POLICY".

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, NAME said: "TYPE OF JUSTIFICATION are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 1 CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 2."

German version

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

NAME (PARTY): "POLICY".

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte NAME: "JUSTIFICATION sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 1 CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 2. LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 3."

Appendix 1.3: Endorsed policies used in the experiment (POLICY)

Each of the six treatment texts states one of six policies endorsed by a politician.

English version of endorsed policies

- Health (A): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."
- Labor classic (B): "Collective bargaining agreements that deliver high wages and good working standards should cover more areas and industries."
- Labor digital (C): "Digital platform workers such as food delivery drivers should have all the rights and privileges of regular employees."
- Pensions (D): "The state needs to guarantee everyone a pension that allows for a decent standard of living."
- Education (E): "Everyone needs to have equal access to high-quality education."
- Transformation (F): "Measures against climate change need to be designed with social justice in mind."

German version

- Health (A): "Gleichberechtigter Zugang zu Gesundheitsversorgung muss für alle sichergestellt sein."
- Labor classic (B): "Tarifverträge, die hohe Löhne und gute Arbeitsbedingungen gewährleisten, sollen mehr Gegenden und Wirtschaftszweige abdecken."
- Labor digital (C): "Digitale Plattformarbeiter, zum Beispiel Essensausfahrer, sollten die gleichen Rechte und Begünstigungen wie normale Arbeitnehmer haben."
- Pensions (D): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."
- Education (E): "Alle Menschen sollen gleichberechtigten Zugang zu Bildung auf hohem Niveau haben."
- Transformation (F): "Die Politik gegen den Klimawandel muss so gestaltet werden, dass die soziale Gerechtigkeit berücksichtigt wird."

Appendix 1.4: Randomized variation of politician names (NAME)

For each of the six endorsed policies, we randomly assign a different gender (male or female) and name of the politician. The names are selected to be neutral and to avoid invoking confounding considerations.

- Names used for German sample: Herbert Brückner, Frank Wilmers, Michael Förster, Heike Volkert, Franziska Ludwig, Antonia Kreiss
- Names used for UK sample: Gary Walker, Neil Jenkins, Robert Barnes, Claire Taylor, Lisa Harvey, Ann Fisher

Appendix 1.5: Randomized variation of party labels (PARTY)

For each of the ten policy statements, we randomly vary the party affiliation of the politician (so that each party is assigned at least three times in Germany and five times in the UK for each participant)

- Parties used in the UK: Labour, Conservatives
- Parties used in Germany: SPD, CDU, Bündnis 90/Die Grünen

Appendix 1.6: Type of justification (TYPE OF JUSTIFICATION)

In each treatment text, the politician mentions one of three types of justifications (treatment 1)

English version of type of justification texts

- Value-based justification: "Values are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices."
- Group-based justification: "The needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices."

- Combined justification: "Values and the needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices" or, randomly alternated with "The needs of groups and values are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices."
- No justification—refusal to justify: "When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker offered no explanation."

German version

- Value-based justification: "Werte sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen."
- Group-based justification: "Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen."
- Combined justification: "Werte und die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen" or, randomly alternated with "Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen und Werte sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen."
- No justification—refusal to justify: "Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, gab NAME keine Erklärung ab."

Appendix 1.7: Language of policy-norm connection

We randomly assign different language politicians use to establish a connection between the justified policy and the norm invoked to justify it.

The varying forms of language are added where "LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 1" and "LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 2" and, for the German version only, "LANGUAGE OF JUSTIFICATION PART 3" are located in the treatment text

English version (part 1 . . . part 2)

- Representation: "This policy stands for. . . and that's why I voted for it."
- Impact: "This policy will have a positive impact and support . . . and that's why I voted for it."
- Mere appeal (no text in part 2): "We need to do more for . . . "

German version

Part 1:

- (Representation) Diese Maßnahme steht für
- (Impact) Diese Maßnahme wird positive Auswirkungen haben und
- (Mere appeal) Wir müssen mehr tun für

Part 2:

- (Representation) ,
- (Impact) fördern,
- (Mere appeal) .

Part 3:

- (Representation) und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt.
- (Impact) und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt.
- (Mere appeal) NO TEXT

Appendix 1.8: Values and groups used in treatment (CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION)

Politicians will invoke one of three values in all treatment conditions that are about values, and one of three groups in all treatment conditions that are about groups. In the combined condition, both value and group are added. This represents the content of justification, which is randomly assigned where "CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION" is located in the treatment text

English version

- Values: Compassion, Loyalty, Fairness
- Groups: Children, Workers, Pensioners

German version

- Values: Mitgefühl, Loyalität, Gerechtigkeit
- Groups: Kinder, Arbeitnehmer, Rentner

Appendix 1.9: Examples of treatment texts

English version

Value / representation

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "Values are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy stands for fairness and that's why I voted for it."

Group / impact

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "The needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy will have a positive impact and support pensioners and that's why I voted for it."

Group / mere appeal

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "The needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. We need to do more for pensioners."

*Combined / value representation * group representation*

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "Values and the needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy stands for fairness and it stands for pensioners and that's why I voted for it."

*Combined / value representation * group impact*

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "Values and the needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy stands for fairness and it will have a positive impact and support pensioners, and that's why I voted for it."

Refusal to justify

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker offered no explanation.

German version

Value / representation

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: "Werte sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme steht für Loyalität, und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt."

Group / impact

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: "Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme wird positive Auswirkungen haben und Kinder fördern, und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt."

Group / mere appeal

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Franziska Ludwig (CDU): "Die Politik gegen den Klimawandel muss so gestaltet werden, dass die soziale Gerechtigkeit berücksichtigt wird."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Franziska Ludwig: "Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Wir müssen mehr tun für Arbeitnehmer."

*Combined / value representation * group representation*

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (SPD): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: "Werte und die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme steht für Mitgefühl und sie steht für Arbeitnehmer, und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt."

*Combined / value representation * group impact*

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (SPD): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: "Werte und die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme steht für Mitgefühl und sie wird positive Auswirkungen haben und Arbeitnehmer fördern, und deshalb habe ich dafür gestimmt."

Refusal to justify

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, gab Frank Wilmers keine Erklärung ab.

Appendix 2: Design Second Experiment

Appendix 2.1: Text introducing the treatment section

Before exposure to the treatment section, participants read the following introductory text

A voting advice application (VAA) is a website that collects information about the views and statements of politicians and political parties to help voters make informed vote choices.

The VAA relies on direct quotes from politicians and parties whenever possible, to make sure that the information it provides is accurate and unbiased. The team running the VAA takes information for the VAA from official party manifestos and from politicians' answers to a questionnaire.

We will now show you ten policy statements from the VAA. They were given in response to the VAA questionnaire by politicians who are currently considering running for a seat in Parliament. In the statements, politicians talk about their views, their votes on different policies, and the reasons for their choices.

As a part of the questionnaire, the VAA team sends politicians a template with certain phrases and asks them to use it when giving answers. This is why some parts of the statements you are about to read will look quite similar. The VAA uses a template so that citizens can easily spot differences and compare politicians as effectively as possible.

Moreover, since we randomly selected the ten statements, **the politicians you will read about can be quite different or quite similar in several ways**, such as their party affiliation or their gender.

Please read the statements carefully, and then answer a few questions about them.

German version

Der „Wahl-O-Mat" ist eine Webseite mit Informationen über die Ansichten und Erklärungen von Politiker/innen und politischen Parteien. Wähler/innen können den „Wahl-O-Mat" nutzen, um sich vor ihrer Wahlentscheidung umfassend zu informieren.

Zur korrekten Übermittlung von Informationen enthält der „Wahl-O-Mat" so oft es geht wortgetreue Aussagen. Diese Aussagen stammen aus den offiziellen Parteiprogrammen sowie aus den Antworten von Politiker/innen auf einen Fragebogen.

Wir zeigen Ihnen nun aus dem „Wahl-O-Mat" **10 Beiträge mit Antworten auf diesen Fragebogen. Sie stammen von Politiker/innen**, die derzeit eine Kandidatur für ein Bundestagsmandat in Erwägung ziehen. In den Beiträgen sprechen die Politiker/innen über ihre Einstellungen, ihr Verhalten bei Abstimmungen über verschiedene politische Maßnahmen und die Gründe für ihre Entscheidungen.

Als Teil des Fragebogens schickt das Team vom „Wahl-O-Mat" den Politiker/innen eine Vorlage mit Formulierungen, die beim Beantworten der Fragen verwendet werden soll. Deswegen sehen manche Abschnitte in den Aussagen, die Sie gleich lesen werden, recht ähnlich aus. Der „Wahl-O-Mat" verwendet eine Vorlage, damit man Unterschiede leicht erkennen und Politiker/innen möglichst effektiv vergleichen kann.

Bei den Politiker/innen, über die sie gleich lesen, können sich bestimmte Eigenschaften häufen, zum Beispiel die Parteizugehörigkeit oder das Geschlecht. Das liegt daran, dass wir die Aussagen per Zufall ausgewählt haben.

Bitte lesen Sie die Aussagen sorgfältig und beantworten Sie dann jeweils ein paar Fragen zu jeder der Aussagen.

Appendix 2.2: Setup of the treatment text

After the introductory text, participants read ten treatment texts (one after another, each with one of ten endorsed policies, in randomized order). Treatment assignment and measurement of dependent variables is conducted separately for each of the ten treatment texts.

English version

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

NAME (PARTY): "POLICY".

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, NAME said: "TYPE OF JUSTIFICATION are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy supports CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION and that's why I am endorsing it."

German version

Per Zufall aus dem "Wahl-O-Mat" ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

NAME (PARTY): "POLICY".

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte NAME: "TYPE OF JUSTIFICATION sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme fördert CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION, und deshalb bin ich dafür."

Appendix 2.3: Endorsed policies used in the experiment (POLICY)

Each of the ten treatment texts states one of ten policies endorsed by a politician. The policies cover ten areas of social policy.

English version of endorsed policies

- Health (A): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."
- Labor classic (B): "Collective bargaining agreements that deliver high wages and good working standards should cover more areas and industries."
- Labor digital (C): "Digital platform workers such as food delivery drivers should have all the rights and privileges of regular employees."
- Pensions (D): "The state needs to guarantee everyone a pension that allows for a decent standard of living."
- Education (E): "Everyone needs to have equal access to high-quality education."
- Transformation (F): "Measures against climate change need to be designed with social justice in mind."
- Regional inequalities (G): "Government should provide more support for regions in our country that are less wealthy."
- European welfare state (H): "Our country needs to cooperate more with other European countries to guarantee comparable social standards."
- Catching up the left behind (I): "Government needs to provide more support for people that are not competitive in the labor market anymore."
- Fair infrastructure investment (J): "We need additional public investment for equal access to high-quality infrastructure, such as electricity grids, internet, and train tracks."

German version of endorsed policies

- Health (A): "Gleichberechtigter Zugang zu Gesundheitsversorgung muss für alle sichergestellt sein."
- Labor classic (B): "Tarifverträge, die hohe Löhne und gute Arbeitsbedingungen gewährleisten, sollen mehr Gegenden und Wirtschaftszweige abdecken."
- Labor digital (C): "Digitale Plattformarbeiter, zum Beispiel Essensausfahrer, sollten die gleichen Rechte und Begünstigungen wie normale Arbeitnehmer haben."
- Pensions (D): "Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht."
- Education (E): "Alle Menschen sollen gleichberechtigten Zugang zu Bildung auf hohem Niveau haben."
- Transformation (F): "Die Politik gegen den Klimawandel muss so gestaltet werden, dass die soziale Gerechtigkeit berücksichtigt wird."
- Regional inequalities (G): "Die Bundesregierung sollte Regionen in unserem Land, die weniger wohlhabend sind, stärker unterstützen."

- European welfare state (H): “Unser Land sollte stärker mit anderen europäischen Ländern kooperieren, um vergleichbare soziale Mindeststandards zu garantieren.”
- Catching up the left behind (I): “Wir brauchen mehr staatliche Unterstützung für Menschen, die auf dem Arbeitsmarkt nicht mehr gefragt sind.”
- Fair infrastructure investment (J): “Wir brauchen zusätzliche staatliche Investitionen für gleichberechtigten Zugang zu hochwertiger Infrastruktur wie Stromnetze, Internet und Bahngleise.”

Appendix 2.4: Randomized variation of politician names (NAME)

For each of the ten endorsed policies, we randomly assign a different gender (male or female) and name of the politician. The names are selected to be neutral and to avoid invoking confounding considerations.

- Names used for German sample: Herbert Brückner, Frank Wilmers, Michael Förster, Markus Krahn, Matthias Schildmann, Heike Volkert, Franziska Ludwig, Antonia Kreiss, Christina Anton, Katrin Frerichs
- Names used for UK sample: Gary Walker, Neil Jenkins, Robert Barnes, Richard Shennan, Benjamin Hill, Claire Taylor, Lisa Harvey, Ann Fisher, Laura Bell, Kate Davies

Appendix 2.5: Randomized variation of party labels (PARTY)

For each of the ten policy statements, we randomly vary the party affiliation of the politician (so that each party is assigned at least three times in Germany and five times in the UK for each participant)

- Parties used in the UK: Labour, Conservatives
- Parties used in Germany: SPD, CDU, Bündnis 90/Die Grünen

Appendix 2.6: Type of justification (TYPE OF JUSTIFICATION)

In each treatment text, the politician will mention one of three types of justifications (treatment 1)

English version of type of justification text

- Value-based justification: “Values are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices.”
- Group-based justification: “The needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices.”
- No justification through mere endorsement: NO TEXT
- No justification through refusal to justify: “When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, NAME offered no explanation.”

German version

- Value-based justification: „Werte sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen.“
- Group-based justification: „Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen.“
- No justification through mere endorsement: NO TEXT
- No justification through refusal to justify: „Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, gab NAME keine Erklärung ab.“

Appendix 2.7: Values and groups used in treatment (CONTENT OF JUSTIFICATION)

English version of specific reasons

Values

- Moral foundations category
  - compassion
  - loyalty
  - fairness
  - authority
- Competitive (Schwartz) values
  - kindness (label of dimension in Schwartz system: benevolence)
  - merit (label of dimension in Schwartz system: achievement; alternative terms: effort, performance)
  - security
  - independence (label of dimension in Schwartz system: self-direction)
- Political values
  - economic coordination (long: an economy coordinated in the public interest, political value 1, SOC-CAP)
  - economic freedom (long: guaranteed economic freedom, political value 2, SOC-CAP)
  - traditional values (protection of traditional values, political value 3, GAL-TAN)
  - personal freedom (long: freedom of expression for different life-styles, political value 4, GAL-TAN)

Groups

- Universally deserving groups
  - children
  - pensioners
  - families
  - young people
- Economic cleavage groups
  - workers
  - business
  - the self-employed
  - the unemployed
- Identity groups
  - migrants
  - rural people
  - urban people
  - homosexual, bisexual, and transgender people

German version

Values

- Moral foundations
  - Mitgefühl
  - Loyalität
  - Gerechtigkeit
  - Autorität
- Competitive (Schwartz) values
  - Wohlwollen
  - Leistung
  - Sicherheit
  - Unabhängigkeit

- Political values
  - wirtschaftspolitische Steuerung
  - wirtschaftliche Freiheit
  - traditionelle Werte
  - persönliche Freiheit

Groups

- Universally deserving groups
  - Kinder
  - Rentner
  - Familien
  - junge Leute
- Economic cleavage groups
  - Arbeitnehmer
  - Unternehmen
  - Selbständige
  - Arbeitslose
- Identity groups
  - Migranten
  - Menschen auf dem Land
  - Menschen in der Großstadt
  - homosexuelle, bisexuelle und transgeschlechtliche Menschen

Appendix 2.9: Examples of treatment texts

English version

Value justifications

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "Values are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy supports fairness and that's why I am endorsing it."

Group justifications

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker said: "The needs of groups are important to me, and they guide my political views and choices. This policy supports children and that's why I am endorsing it."

No justification—mere endorsement

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): "Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone."

No justification—refusal to justify

Randomly selected example of a policy statement from Voting Advice Application (VAA)

Gary Walker (Conservative): “Equal access to health care must be guaranteed for everyone.”

When asked about the reasons for endorsing this policy, Gary Walker offered no explanation.

German version

Value justification

Per Zufall aus dem „Wahl-O-Mat“ ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): „Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht.“

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: „Werte sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme fördert Mitgefühl, und deshalb bin ich dafür.“

Group justification

Per Zufall aus dem „Wahl-O-Mat“ ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): „Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht.“

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, sagte Frank Wilmers: „Die Bedürfnisse von Gruppen sind mir wichtig, und sie bestimmen meine politischen Standpunkte und Entscheidungen. Diese Maßnahme fördert Kinder, und deshalb bin ich dafür.“

No justification—mere endorsement

Per Zufall aus dem „Wahl-O-Mat“ ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): „Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht.“

No justification—refusal to justify

Per Zufall aus dem „Wahl-O-Mat“ ausgewähltes Beispiel einer politischen Aussage

Frank Wilmers (Bündnis 90 / Die Grünen): „Der Staat soll allen Menschen eine Rente garantieren, die einen angemessenen Lebensstandard ermöglicht.“

Nach den Gründen für die Zustimmung zu der Maßnahme gefragt, gab Frank Wilmers keine Erklärung ab.

Appendix 5: Dictionaries Automated Text Analyses

Appendix 5.1: Used dictionaries and where to find them

- The English version of the moral foundations dictionary used for the identification of "values" in study 1 and "values – moral foundations" in study 2 is from (Frimer et al. 2019). It is available at https://osf.io/ezn37/files/whjt2.

- The German version of the moral foundations dictionary used for the identification of "values" in study 1 and "values – moral foundations" in study 2 is from (Bos and Minihold 2022). It is available at https://doi.org/10.1111/pops.12739.

- The English version of the "basic values" dictionary used for the identification of "values—basic values" in study 2 is from (Ponizovskiy et al. 2020). It is available at https://doi.org/10.1002/per.2294.

- The German version of the "basic values" dictionary used for the identification of "values—basic values" in study 2 was translated by the authors from the English version provided by (Ponizovskiy et al. 2020). The German version is provided below as Appendix 5.2

- The English version of the groups dictionary used for the identification of "groups" in studies 1 and 2 is from (Thau 2019). It is available at https://doi.org/10.1177/00323217177444

- The German version of the groups dictionary used for the identification of "groups" in studies 1 and 2 was translated and adapted by the authors from the English version provided by (Thau 2019). The German version is provided below as Appendix 5.3

- The English and German dictionaries of policy behaviors were developed by the authors and are provided below as Appendix 5.4

Appendix 5.2: German "basic values" dictionary (translated by the authors from Ponizovskiy et al. 2020)

1: Values-SE (Security) Abschirmung, Abwehr, abwehren, abwehrend, Abwehrkräfte, Alarm,, angegriffen, aufgeräumt, aufmerksam, Aufmerksamkeit, Aufwand, Barriere, Beachtung, bedacht, bedrohen, bedrohlich, bedroht, Bedrohung, Bedrohungen, behutsam, Behutsamkeit, Berechnung, Beschaulichkeit, Beschützer, besorgt, Beunruhigung, bewachen, bewachend, Bewacher, bewahren, bewahrend, defensiv, drohen, Drohung, Drohungen, erhalten, erhaltend, Erkrankung, Erlösung, ermahnen, erschrocken, Feinde, Folgen, Fortbestand, fortbestehen, fortbestehend, Garantie, Gefahr, gefährlich, gelassen, Gelassenheit, gesichert, Gesundheit, Gewahrsam, Gewalt, gewarnt, Gewährleistung, harmlos, Heil, Heimlichkeit, Hemmnis, Hindernis, Hürde, hüten, hütend, Hüter, katastrophal, Konsequenzen, Krankheit, Krise, Leiden, mahnen, mahnend, Mühe, Mündel, Obacht, Obhut, ordentlich, Ordnung, Plage, Privatsphäre, rein, retten, Ruhe, ruhig, Rückzug, Rückzugsort, Rüstung, sauber, Schaden, Schild, Schreck, Schrecken, Schutz, Schutzbefohlener, Schutzgebiet, Schutzmaßnahmen, Schutzort, Schweigen, Schwelle, Schäden, schützen, schützend, sicher, sicherer, Sicherheit, sichern, sichernd, Sicherung, Sorge, sorgfältig, stabil, Stabilität, Standfestigkeit, Stille, Umsicht, umsichtig, unbedenklich, ungefährdet, ungefährlich, unschädlich, verbergen, Verdecktheit, verhindern, Verkleidung, Versicherung, verstecken, verteidigen, verteidigend, Verteidigung, Verwahrung, Vorausschau, Voraussicht, Vorkehrungen, Vorsicht, vorsichtig, Vorsichtsmaßnahmen, Wache, wachsam, warnen, warnend, Warnung, wohlbehalten, Wächter, Zuflucht, ängstlich, Ärger, Überleben, überleben, überlebend

2: Values-CO (Conformity) Abkommen, achtet, Achtung, Allgemeinheit, amtlich, anerkannt, anerkennt, Anerkennung, Anforderung, angebracht, angemessen, Anordnung, anpassen, Anpassungsfähigkeit, Anstand, Anstandsregel, Anweisung, Anweisungen, Aufbau, aufrechterhaltend, ausweichen, ausweichend, autorisiert, Autorisierung, bedient, Befehle, befolgen, Befugnis, befugt, begehend, Begrenzungen, begründet, Behörden, bekannt, Benehmen, Benimmregel, Berechtigung, bescheiden, Bescheidenheit, Beschluss, bestellen, Bestrafung, bevollmächtigt, Bevollmächtigung, bewahrend, Bewahrung, bewilligend, brach, brechen, Dekret, Demut, demütig, diente, Disziplin, Ehrfurcht, ehrlich, ehrlicherweise, eindrucksvoll, eingeschränkt, einhalten, Einhaltung, Einheit, Einigkeit, Einklang, Einrichtung, einschränkend, Einschränkungen, Einverständnis, einwilligen, Einwilligung, Entgegenkommen, Entscheidung, Entschließung, erforderlich, erfüllen, Erfüllung, Ergebenheit, erhaltend, Erhaltung, Erlass, ermächtigt, Ermächtigung, Etikette, Fassung, Fasten, festgelegt, Festlegung, Festlegungen, Flexibilität, formal, formell, förmlich, geachtet, Gebilde, gebrochen, Geduld, geeignet, Gefälligkeit, gehorchen, Gehorsam, geläufig, genehmigend, genötigt, Gesamtheit, Gesetz, Gesetze, Gesetzgebung, gesetzlich, gestattend, Gewissheit,

gewohnt, Glaubhaftigkeit, Glaubwürdigkeit, Gleichklang, Gliederung, Grenzen, Grund, hergebracht, Herrschaft, herrschend, Hierarchie, höflich, Identität, Integrität, Kombination, Konkordanz, Konsens, Konsensus, konservativ, konserviert, Konvention, konventionell, Konventionen, Konzession, legitim, Mainstream, Maßnahme, Maßnahmen, Maßstäbe, muss, Muss, notwendig, Obrigkeit, offiziell, Organisation, passend, periodisch, Pflichten, Prozedur, Rangordnung, Recht, rechtlich, rechtmäßig, Rechtschaffenheit, Rechtsetzung, Regel, regelmäßig, Regeln, regierend, Regulierung, Regulierungen, repetitiv, reservieren, Resignation, Resolution, Respekt, respektiert, routinemäßig, Schande, Schicklichkeit, Schüchternheit, Standards, Strafe, Struktur, System, treffend, Umgangsformen, unangemessen, unerhört, ungebührlich, ungehörig, unpassend, unsachgemäß, Untergebene, Untergebener, Untergeordnete, Untergeordneter, unterordnen, unterwerfen, Unterworfene, Unterworfener, Verantwortlichkeit, Verantwortlichkeiten, verboten, Vereinbarung, Verfügung, Vergleichbarkeit, Vergleichsmaßstäbe, Verknüpfung, verletzen, verletzt, verletzte, vermeiden, vermeidend, vermieden, vernünftig, Verordnung, verpflichtet, Verpflichtung, Verpflichtungen, vertrauen, Vertrauen, vertraut, vertraute, vertrauter, Vollmacht, Voraussetzung, vorbehalten, Vorgehensweise, vorherrschend, Vorschrift, Vorschriften, Weisung, weisungsgemäß, wiederholend, wiederkehrend, Zugeständnis, zurückhalten, zurückhaltend, Zurückhaltung, zustimmen, Zuvorkommenheit, zweckmäßig, zögern, Ähnlichkeit, Ämter, Übereinkommen, Übereinkunft, Übereinstimmung

3: Values-TR (Tradition) Abkömmlinge, Abstammung, Ahnen, Ahnenkunde, Allah, allmächtig, Allmächtige, Allmächtiger, Anbetung, Angewohnheit, Angewohnheiten, Anmut, Atheist, atheistisch, Bedenken, betend, Bibel, Brut, Christ, Christen, Christenheit, Christentum, Christin, Clan, Ehe, Eheschließung, Eheschließungen, ehrend, Ehrfurcht, Ehrung, Einrichtung, Engel, Erbe, Erbschaft, Ethik, ethisch, Folklore, Folkloristik, fromm, Gebet, Gebote, geheiligt, Gemeinde, Generationen, Gepflogenheit, Gepflogenheiten, Geschwister, gesegnet, Gewissen, Gewohnheit, Gewohnheiten, gewohnt, gewöhnt, Glaube, gläubig, Gläubige, Gläubigkeit, Gnade, Gott, Gottesdienst, gottesfürchtig, Gottheit, Göttlichkeit, Heiland, heilig, heilige Schrift, Heiligkeit, Heirat, Heiraten, Himmel, himmlisch, historisch, Institution, Islam, Jesus, Kapelle, Katholik, katholisch, Kirche, Kirchen, Kongregation, korrumpiert, Missionar, Mohammed, Moral, moralisch, Moschee, Moslem, Muhammed, mystisch, Mythos, Nachfahren, orthodox, predigen, predigend, Predigt, Predigten, Priester, Prophet, Protestant, Rechtschaffenheit, Reinheit, Religion, Religionen, religiös, Retter, Riten, Ritual, Rituale, Ritus, Seele, Segen, segnen, segnete, Segnung, Segnungen, Sippe, Skrupel, Sünde, Teufel, Theologie, Tradition, traditionell, Traditionen, traditionsgemäß, Tugend, Unschuld, verdammt, verdorben, Verehrung, Vererbung, verflucht, verheiratet, Vermächtnis, Vertrauen, Verwandte, Volk, Volkskunde, Volkstum, Vorfahren, Vorschriften, Vorsehung, Wurzeln, Zeremonie, Zeremonien, Überzeugung

4: Values-BE (Benevolence) Alliierter, Anleitung, Assistenz, assistieren, Assoziation, aufrichtig, Bedarf, Bedauern, Begleiter, Begleiterin, Begleiterinnen, Behandlung, behutsam, Beitrag, Bekannte, Bekannter, Bekanntschaft, Beratung, Beteiligung, betreuen, Betreuung, Beziehung, brauche, Brüderschaft, Cousin, dankte, delikat, Ehefrau, Ehemann, ehrlich, Eltern, Empathie, empfindlich, Erbarmen, ermuntern, ermunternd, ermuntert, Ermunterung, Familie, Familien, Freund, Freunde, freundlich, Freundlichkeit, Freundschaft, fühlen, fühlend, Fürsorge, fürsorgen, fürsorglich, Gastfreundschaft, Gastlichkeit, Gefährte, Gefährten, Gefährtin, Gefährtinnen, Gefühl, Gemeinschaft, gemeinschaftlich, Generösität, Genossenschaft, Geschenk, Großeltern, Großmutter, Großziehen, Großzügigkeit, Güte, gütig, helfe, helfend, Hilfe, hilfreich, Intimität, Kameradschaft, Kooperative, Kummer, Liebe, lieben, Liebenswürdigkeit, loyal, Loyalität, Mama, mitfühlend, Mitgefühl, Mitleid, Mutter, Nachbarn, Nachbarschaft, Nähe, Oma, Partizipation, Pflege, pflegen, Ratschlag, Redlichkeit, Sanftheit, sanftmütig, sich verlassen, Sorge, Sympathie, sympathisch, treu, Treue, unterstützen, unterstützend, Unterstützung, Untersützung, Vater, verantwortlich, Verantwortlichkeit, Verantwortlichkeiten, Verantwortung, Verband, Verbündeter, Vereinigung, vergeben, vergebend, Vergebung, verlässlich, verständnissvoll, Vertrauen, vertrauenswürdig, Vorliebe, Wohlwollen, Wärme, Zugehörigkeit, Zuneigung, zuständig, Zuständigkeit, Zuständigkeiten, zuverlässig, Zuverlässigkeit, Zuwendung, Zärtlichkeit

5: Values-UN (Universalism) Abgeklärtheit, abgesprochen, abgestimmt, Akzeptanz, akzeptieren, allgemeingültig, Allgemeinheit, anerkennen, anerkennend, Anerkennung, Anlage, anmutig, ansprechen, Anstand, Anteil, Aufrichtigkeit, Ausbalancieren, Ausgleich, ausgleichend, Auslegung, Auswahl, Balance, bedeutend, Bedeutung, Befreiung, Begleitung, beschützen, beschützend, beschützt, bestätigen, bestätigend, Bestätigung, Dekorum, Demokraten, Demokratie, demokratisch, Diskriminierung, divers, Diversität, Einheit, Einigkeit, Einigung, Entschädigung, erfreulich, Erkenntnis, Erklärung, ermächtigt, fair, Fairness, Freiheit, Freiheiten, Friede, Frieden, friedlich, Fusion, geistig, Gelassenheit, Gemeinde, gemeinnützig, Gemeinschaft, Gemeinschaften, generös, gerecht, Gerechtigkeit, geschmackvoll, geschützt, Gesellschaft, Gier, gierig, Gleichgewicht, Gleichheit, Gnade, grausam,

großzügig, Habsucht, habsüchtig, Interpretation, Kameradschaft, Klima, Koalition, Kollaboration, komplex, Kompromiss, Kooperation, kooperativ, koordiniert, Kultur, Lauterkeit, liberal, Menschheit, Menschlichkeit, Mischung, Natur, natürlich, Opfer, partnerschaftlich, Rechte, Schadensersatz, Schutz, schön, Schönheit, schützend, schützt, Solidarität, Sortiment, sozial, spirituell, Takt, teilen, teilend, tolerant, Toleranz, tolerieren, toleriert, tolerierte, Umgebung, umgebungsbedingt, Umwelt, unfair, ungerecht, Ungerechtigkeit, Ungleichbehandlung, Union, universell, Verbindung, Verbundenheit, Vereinigug, vereint, Verknüpfung, verletzbar, verletzlich, Verschmelzung, verstehen, Verständnis, Vielfalt, vielfältig, Volksherrschaft, weise, Weisheit, Wiedergutmachung, Willkommen, willkommen, willkommend, wohltätig, wunderschön, Zusammenarbeit, Zusammenschluss, Ähnlichkeit, Ästhetik, ökologisch

6: Values-SD (Self-Direction) Absicht, Ahnung, Ahnungslosigkeit, Akademie, Akte, Aktion, Aktionen, Aktivist, Aktivität, Aktivitäten, Analyse, Ansicht, Anstrengung, Anstrengungen, Argumentation, Aufgeklärtheit, Aufklärung, auflehnen, Auflehnung, aufmerksam, Aufstand, ausbildend, Ausbildung, ausbrüten, Auseinandersetzung, Auswahl, Auswertung, auswählen, beabsichtigen, beabsichtigt, beansprechend, beanspruchen, bedacht, Begabung, Begabungen, Begründung, behaupten, belesen, Beobachtung, berühmt, besessen, Besinnung, besonders, Bessenheit, bestimmt, Bestimmtheit, Bestimmung, Betrachtung, Beweisführung, Bewusstsein, bildend, Bildung, Brillianz, brüten, brütend, Charakterstärke, clever, Courage, dachte, denke, Denken, denken, denkend, denkt, direkt, Disput, Einbildung, Einblick, Einfallsreichtum, Einfühlung, Einfühlungsvermögen, Eingebung, Einkehr, Einsicht, Einstellung, Eitelkeit, empören, Empörung, Entdeckung, entfaltend, entscheiden, Entscheidung, entschlossen, Entschlossenheit, Entschluss, entwickeln, entwickelnd, erfinderisch, Erfindungsgabe, Erkenntnis, Erleuchtung, Ernst, Ernsthaftigkeit, erschaffen, erschafft, Esprit, Fachhochshule, Folgerichtigkeit, Fortschrift, frei, Freiheit, Freizeitbeschäftigung, Fähigkeit, gedanke, Gedanken, Gedankengang, Geist, gelehrsam, gelehrt, Gelehrte, Gelehrter, Genialität, Geringschätzung, gescheit, gesinnt, gewandt, Gewissheit, Großartigkeit, Grund, Grübelei, Grübeln, handeln, handelnd, Handelnder, handelte, Handlung, Handlungen, Hang, Hingabe, Hingebung, Hobby, Hochschule, Idee, Ignoranz, Individualität, indviduell, Initiative, Inspiration, inspirierend, inspiriert, Instinkt, Intellekt, intelligent, Intelligenz, intellktuell, Intention, Interesse, Intuition, klug, Kolleg, Konfrontation, Kontemplation, kontrovers, Kontroverse, Kreation, kreativ, Kreativität, kritisch, künstlerisch, lehrreich, Lektionen, lenkend, lernen, lernend, Logik, Meditation, Meinung, Missachtung, Mumm, Mut, nachdenklich, Nachgrübeln, Nachsinnen, Neigung, neugierig, Oberschule, original, originell, Philosophie, Plan, planen, plant, Prinzipien, Protest, Prüfung, rasen, Reflektion, Reflexion, reif, Resolution, Revolte, revoltieren, Richtung, Rückgrat, Rückschau, sausen, schaffen, schafft, schlau, Schneid, Schulbildung, Schulung, Schöpfergeist, schöpferisch, Schöpfung, selbstbewußt, Selbstüberwindung, Skepsis, skeptisch, Spekulation, speziell, Spirit, Sprint, sprinten, Spurt, spurten, Streit, strittig, Talent, Talente, Tapferkeit, Trieb, Trotz, Trotzreaktion, umstritten, unabhängig, Unabhängigkeit, Universität, Unkenntnis, unmittelbar, Unternehmen, unternehmend, unternehmerisch, Unternehmung, Unternehmungsgeist, Unternehmungslust, Untersuchung, unverkennbar, unverwechselbar, Unwissenheit, Verstand, Vision, vorhaben, Vorstellung, Vorstellungskraft, Vorstellungsvermögen, Wahl, weise, Wille, Willen, Willenskraft, Wissen, wissend, Wissenschaft, Wissenschaftler, Wissenschaftlerin, Witz, wählen, Ziel, Ziele, Zweck, Überprüfung, Überzeugung

7: Values-ST (Stimulation) Abenteuer, Abwechslung, Adrenalin, anders, angeregt, angetrieben, anregend, Anstrengung, Antrieb, atemberaubend, Aufhebens, aufregend, Aufregung, Aufruhr, aufrühren, außergewöhnlich, Beanspruchung, beispiellos, Belastung, Belebtheit, belustigend, Belustigung, bemerkenswert, besonders, Betrieb, Betriebsamkeit, Bewegung, Chance, Chancen, Courage, Drama, dramatisch, Dreistigkeit, Durchbruch, Dynamik, Dynamiken, dynamisch, Eifer, einzigartig, Ekstase, Energie, energiegeladen, Energien, energisch, entdecken, entdeckend, Entdecker, Entdeckerin, entdeckt, Entdeckung, Entdeckungen, Enthusiasmus, enthusiastisch, Erfahrungen, Erfindung, Erfindungen, erforschend, Erforschung, Erkundung, erregen, Experiment, extrem, faszinierend, Feigling, Forscher, Forscherin, Forschungsreisende, Forschungsreisender, fortschrittlich, fremdartig, Gegenrede, gelangweilt, Gelegenheit, Gelegenheiten, geschockt, Geschäftigkeit, Glamour, Glanz, Hast, Hektik, herausfordernd, Herausforderung, Herausforderungen, herausgefordert, Hysterie, Impuls, Inbrunst, innovativ, Instabilität, instail, Intensität, intensiv, interessant, irregulär, Kampf, Kühnheit, labil, Labilität, Langeweile, Laune, Lebenskraft, Leidenschaft, leidenschaftlich, Leidenschaftlichkeit, Motivation, Mut, mysteriös, Nervenkitzel, Nervosität, neu, neuartig, neuer, neuester, Neugierde, Neuheit, neulich, neuste, paranoid, Passion, progressiv, radikal, Rausch, regen, revolutionär, Risiken, Risiko, Rummel, Schock, Schwung, Spannung, spontan, stimulierend, stimuliert, Streben, Störung, tapfer, Tatkraft, Temprament, Treiben, Trubel, Tumult, unbekannt, unberechenbar, Unbeständigkeit, unerhört, Ungeduld, ungewiss, Ungewissheit, ungewohnt, unregelmäßig, Unruhe, unsicher, Unsicherheit, unterhaltsam, Unterhaltung, Unternehmung, unterschiedlich, Unverfrorenheit, unvorhersehbar,

verblüffend, Vergnügen, vergnüglich, Verlangen, verschieden, Versuch, Versuche, versuchen, versuchend, versucht, Verwegenheit, Veränderungen, Vielfalt, Vitalität, Vorhaben, wagemutig, wagen, wagend, Wagnis, Wandel, Wandlungen, wankelmütig, Wechsel, Widerspruch, Änderungen, überraschend, Übung

8: Values-HE (Hedonism) Ablenkung, Abwechslung, amüsieren, angenehm, Anziehung, Anziehungskraft, Appetit, Attraktion, attraktiv, aufgekratzt, ausruhen, Auszeit, befriedigend, Befriedigung, begehren, Begeisterung, Begierde, Behagen, Behaglichkeit, bequem, bequemlich, Bequemlichkeit, Charm, Durst, Ekstase, Empfindung, Entschädigung, entspannen, Entspannung, Entzücken, entzückend, entzückt, Entzückung, erfreuend, erfreulich, erfreut, Erfrischung, Erfüllung, erholen, Erholung, Erholungsaufenthalt, Erholungsurlaub, Erleichterung, erotisch, ersehnen, Euphorie, Faszination, Feier, Feierlichkeiten, Feiern, Ferien, Fetisch, Freizeit, Freude, Freuden, Freudentaumel, fröhlich, Fröhlichkeit, Funkeln, Gefühl, Gelächter, genießen, genießend, genießt, genossen, Genugtuung, Genuss, Genuß, Geschmack, Glitzern, Glück, glücklich, glücklicher, Gratifikation, heiter, hocherfreut, Hochgefühl, Humor, Jubel, jubeln, Komfort, komfortabel, komisch, Kompensation, Komödie, kurzweilig, köstlich, Lachen, Leichtigkeit, Liebreiz, Lust, lustig, Lustspiel, Muße, Optimismus, Orgasmus, Party, Pause, pausieren, Rast, rasten, Rauschzustand, Reiz, reizend, Ruhe, ruhen, Scherz, scherzen, scherzend, scherzhaft, Schwäche, Sehnsucht, Sex, Sexualität, sexuell, sexy, Sinnesfreuden, sinnlich, Spaß, spaßig, Spiel, Spiele, spielen, spielerisch, unerfreulich, Ungezwungenheit, unterhalten, unterhaltend, unterhaltsam, Unterhaltung, urkomisch, Urlaub, veralbern, Verführung, Vergnügen, verkosten, Verlangen, verlangen, Verlockung, Versuchung, Verzauberung, Verzückung, Werben, Werbung, Witz, Wonnen, Wunsch, wünschen, Zauber, Zufriedenheit, Zuversicht

9: Values-AC (Achievement) Abschluss, ambitioniert, anerkannt, anerkennen, anerkennt, Anlagen, Anwachsen, Arbeit, Arbeitsstelle, Arbeitsstellen, Arbeitsverhältnis, Aufnahmefähigkeit, Aufstieg, Ausbeute, Ausbildung, ausführen, befähigt, Befähigung, befördert, Beförderung, begreifen, Beherrschung, beliebt, Belohnung, Belohnungen, Bereitschaft, Beschäftigung, besiegen, beste, bestes, Bestreben, Betrieb, bewerkstelligen, bezwingen, Champion, effektiv, effizient, Effizienz, Ehre, Eifer, Einbuße, Einsatzfähigkeit, Eleganz, Entwicklung, Erfahrung, Erfolg, Erfolge, erfolgreich, Ergebnisse, ergiebig, Ergiebigkeit, Erhabenheit, erreichen, erreicht, erringen, Errungenschaft, ertragbringend, ertragreich, Ertüchtigung, erzielen, erzielt, etabliert, Expertise, Fachkenntnis, fachmännisch, Fachwissen, feiern, Fertigkeit, Fertigkeiten, Fortschreiten, Fortschritt, fähig, Fähigkeit, Fähigkeiten, Gehirn, gelang, Gelingen, gelingen, gelingend, Geschicklichkeit, Geschäft, Gewandheit, Gewerbe, Gewinn, gewinnen, gewonnen, Gipfel, Grips, großartigste, großartigster, großartigstes, größtes, Handwerk, Hirn, höchste, höchstes, Intelligenz, Job, Jobs, Kapazität, kompetent, Kompetenz, kompetitiv, Konkurrenz, konkurrenzfähig, konkurrieren, konkurrierend, Können, Leistung, Leistungsvermögen, locker, Lohn, Meister, Meisterschaft, Niederlage, Perfektion, populär, produktiv, professionell, Qualifikation, qualifiziert, Qualität, Sachkenntnis, Sachverstand, schaffen, Schulung, schätzen, Sieg, Sieger, stolz, Stolz, top, Training, Unternehmen, verbessern, verbessernd, Verbesserung, Verbesserungen, Verdienst, Verlieren, Verlust, versiert, Verstand, Vervollständigung, verwirklichen, vollbringen, Vollendung, voranbringen, Vorankommen, Vorteil, Wachsen, Wachstum, Wert, wertschätzen, Wertschätzung, Wertsteigerung, Wettbewerb, wettbewerbsfähig, wetteifern, wetteifernd, Würde, zugkräftig, Zustimmung, Zuwachs

10: Values-PO (Power) aggressiv, akquirieren, Angriff, Ansehen, Attacke, Aufsicht, Ausgangspunkt, ausgefallen, Auszeichnung, Autorität, Bargeld, Beaufsichtigung, Bedeutung, Beeinflussung, Befehl, befehlen, befugt, berechtigt, Besitz, Besoldung, besser, Betriebsmittel, Bezüge, Bonus, Cash, Demütigung, dominant, Dominanz, dominieren, egoistisch, eigennützug, Eigentum, Eigentümerschaft, Einfluss, einflussreich, einheimsen, Einkauf, einkaufen, Einkommen, Einkommensquelle, Einkommensquellen, Einnahme, Einnahmen, einträglich, Elite, Entlohnung, Erhöhung, erlangen, Erlöse, Erniedrigung, erobern, Eroberung, Ertrag, ertragreich, Erträge, Erträgnisse, Erwerb, Erwzingen, erzwingen, Erzwingung, erzwungen, extravagant, Forderung, Forderungen, führen, Führung, Führungskraft, Fülle, Gehalt, Geld, Geltung, Geschäfte, Geschäftsführung, Geschäftsleitung, gestärkt, Gewalt, Gewinn, gewinnbringend, Gewinne, gewinnen, gewinnend, Handel, Handeln, Hebung, Herrschaft, Herrschaftsgebiet, herrschend, Inhaberschaft, Interessen, Kaliber, Kampf, Kapital, kaufen, kommandieren, Kommando, Kommerz, Kontrolle, kontrollierend, Kraft, kämpfen, Käufe, Leitung, Lohn, Luxus, Löhne, Macht, Management, Manipulation, Mehrertrag, Mehrwert, Monopol, Monopolstellung, mächtig, Nutzen, Nutzwert, Nützlichkeit, Platin, Position, Potential, Potenzial, Privileg, Profit, profitabel, Profite, Quote, Rang, reich, reichste, reichster, Reichtum, rentabel, Ressourcen, Rückgrat, schick, schwach, Schwäche, Schwächen, schwächer, selbstsüchtig, Sieg, Stand, stark, Status, Stellung, streben, streitbar, streitlustig, Stärke, Stärken, Supervision, teuer, Triumph, Unternehmensleitung,

Verdienen, Verdienst, Vergütung, Vermögen, vermögend, Vermögensstand, Volkswirtschaft, voran, voraus, Vorherrschaft, Vorteil, Vorzug, Wettkampf, Wirkung, Wirtschaft, wohlhabend, Wohlstand, Zugabe, Zugewinn, Zwang, zwangsweise, zwingend, überlegen, Überlegenheit, Überschuss

Appendix 5.3: German Group dictionary (translated and adapted by the authors from Thau 2019)

Alleinstehende, Alte Leute, Arbeiter, Arbeitskräfte, Arbeitslose, Ärzte, Arme, Asylsuchende, Ausländer, Banken, Bauern, Beamte, Bedürftige, Beschäftigte, Betriebsräte, Christ, Deutsche, Eigentümer, Einkommensschwache, Einwanderer, Eltern, Erwerbslose, Facharbeiter, Familie, Frau, Freie Wirtschaft, Geringverdiener, Geschäft, Gewerkschaften, Gewerkschaftler, Gleichgeschlechtlich, Gutverdiener, Hausbesitzer, Hautfarbe, Heterosexuell, Hilfsbedürftige, Homosexuell, Immigrant, Jude, Jugend, Junge, Junge Leute, Junge Menschen, Kinder, Kindergärtner, KMU, Kranke, Ländlich, Landwirte, Lehrer, lesbisch, LGBTQ, Lohnempfänger, Mädchen, Mann, Medizinisches Personal, Mieter, Migrationshintergrund, Migrant, Mittleres Alter, Mittelklasse, Mittelschicht, Mittelstand, Muslim, Niedrigverdiener, Öffentlicher Dienst, Patient, Pensionäre, Pflegebedürftige, Pflegekraft, Polizist, Queer, Reiche, Religion, Rentner, Reservisten, Schulbildung, Schwul, Selbstständige, Single, Soldaten, Sozialhilfeempfänger, Stadt, Städte, Städtisch, Studenten, Studierende, Transgender, Unternehmen, Unternehmer, Verheiratete, Vertriebene, Vorstädte, Wirtschaft, Wohlhabende, Zugezogene

Appendix 5.4: Dictionary identifying different policy behaviors (views, demands, and actions)

Demands
English: demand, call, press, insist, petition, clamor, urge
German: fordern, verlangen, bestehen, drängen, pochen, einfordern, plädieren
Actions
English: introduce, propose, draft, implement, enact, sponsor, amend, repeal, adopt, table, ratify, pass, vote, sign, authorize, veto, facilitate, advance
German: einführen, umsetzen, einführen, erlassen, fördern, sponsern, ändern, aufheben, entwerfen, umsetzen, annehmen, einreichen, ratifizieren, verabschieden, voranbringen, ermöglichen, abstimmen, unterzeichnen, autorisieren, verhindern
Views
English: assert, claim, maintain, affirm, contend, declare, state, emphasize, warn, express, believe, feel, voice
German: behaupten, beteuern, feststellen, bekräftigen, versichern, zum Ausdruck bringen, ausdrücken, meinen, glauben, finden, warnen, betonen

Appendix 6: Results Automated Text Analyses

Note: The list of groups and values administered in the experiments has to be the same in both countries. To make sure that each country's unique results contribute equally to the final list (independent of the number of total mentions, which is smaller in the UK given the smaller number of available texts), we determined the rank order of values and groups in each country based on numbers of mentions, and then included groups and values into the experiment according to their average rank based on rank orderings in the two countries.

Appendix 6.1: Groups study 1

Germany: Ranking of groups and number of mentions
1. Children (521) 2. Pensioners (356) 3. Workers (315) [Humans (706)] [Everyone (376)]
Note: Only partial groups (suitable for partial justifications, the topic of our experiments) are included. "Humans" and "everyone" are universal group references rather than partial groups, and therefore not included.
UK: ranking of groups, and number of mentions
1. Workers (126) 2. Pensioners (107) 3. Teachers (98) 4. Unions (55) 5. Public servants (42)
Average ranks of "partial" groups in the two countries, with German translations
1. Pensioners (Rentner) 2. Workers (Arbeitnehmer) 3. Children (Kinder)

Appendix 6.2: Groups study 2

Universally deserving groups

Germany: ranking of groups (and German translations), based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Children (Kinder) 2. Pensioners (Rentner) 3. Parents (Eltern) 4. Families (Familien) 5. Young people (Junge Leute) 6. Patients (Patienten)

UK: ranking of groups, based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Pensioners 2. Children 3. Families 4. Young people 5. Patients

Average ranks in both countries

1. Children (Kinder) 2. Pensioners (Rentner) 3. Families (Familien) 4. Young people (Junge Leute) 5. Patients (Patienten) 6. Parents (Eltern)

Economic cleavage groups

Germany: ranking of groups (and German translations), based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Workers (Arbeitnehmer) 2. Business (Unternehmer) 3. Unemployed (Arbeitslose) 4. Self-Employed (Selbständige) 5. Poor people (Arme)

UK: ranking of groups, based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Workers 2. Business 3. Self-employed 4. Poor people 5. Unemployed

Average ranks in both countries

1. Workers (Arbeitnehmer) 2. Business (Unternehmer) 3. Self-employed (Selbständige) 4. Unemployed (Arbeitslose) 5. Poor people (Arme)

Identity groups

Germany: ranking of groups (and German translations), based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Migrants 2. Homosexual, bisexual, and transgender people

UK: ranking of groups, based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. Migrants (and asylum seekers) 2. Rural people 3. Urban people

Average ranks in both countries

1. Migrants (Migranten) 2. Homosexual, bisexual, and transgender people (homosexuelle, bisexuelle und transgeschlechtliche Menschen) 3. Rural people (Menschen auf dem Land) 4. Urban people (Menschen in der Großstadt)

Appendix 6.3: Moral foundations, studies 1 and 2

Germany: Ranking of value dimensions with German translations, number of mentions / total mentions, and share of mentions

1. Compassion (Mitgefühl): 1607 / 5939 = 27.1 2. Fairness (Gerechtigkeit): 1563 / 5939 = 26.3 3. Loyalty (Loyalität): 1217 / 5939 = 20.5 4. Authority (Autorität): 782 / 5939 = 13.2 5. Purity (Reinheit): 770 / 5939 = 13.0

UK: Ranking of value dimensions, number of mentions / total mentions, and share of mentions

1. Compassion: 1313 / 3150 = 41.7 2. Loyalty: 1196 / 3150 = 38.0 3. Authority: 386 / 3150 = 12.3 4. Fairness: 186 / 3150 = 5.9 5. Purity: 69 / 3150 = 2.2

Average ranks (and average shares of mentions) in the two countries

1. (1+1) Compassion: 34.4 2. (3+2) Loyalty: 29.3 3. (2+4) Fairness: 16.1 4. (4+3) Authority: 12.8 5. (5+5) Purity: 7.6

Appendix 6.4: Basic values, study 2

Germany: Ranking of value dimensions (and German translations) based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. achievement/merit (Leistung) 2. self-direction/independence (Unabhängigkeit) 3. conformity (Konformität/Anpassung) 4. power (Macht) 5. universalism (Universalismus 6. benevolence/kindness (Wohlwollen) 7. security (Sicherheit) 8. stimulation (Anregung/Stimulation) 9. hedonism (Hedonismus/Vergnügen)) 10. tradition (Tradition)

UK: Ranking of value dimensions based on number of mentions, beginning with the highest

1. benevolence 2. achievement 3. security 4. self-direction 5. universalism 6. power 7. conformity 8. stimulation 9. hedonism 10. tradition

Average ranks in the two countries

1. achievement (1.5) 2. self-direction (3) 3. benevolence (3.5) 4. security (5) 4. power (5) 4. universalism (5) 4. conformity (5) 8. stimulation (8) 9. hedonism (9) 10. tradition (10)

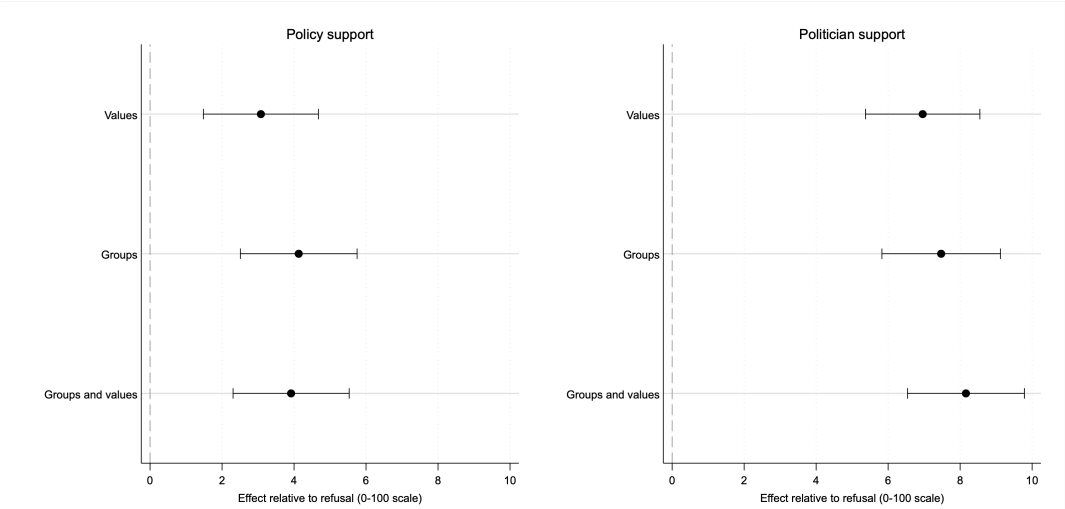
Note: In addition to the top three results (achievement, self-direction, and benevolence), we selected security (rather than conformity, power, or universalism). The four values (security, conformity, power, and universalism) jointly occupy the overall fourth rank (with an average of 5 between the two countries) and from that point of view, could all have been selected. First, we selected security over conformity because security represents a clearly separate value dimension that adds more variation to the analysis, while conformity can be understood as the opposite of self-direction. Second, we selected security over power and universalism because power and universalism are not in the top three of any country, while security is in the top three of basic values in the UK.

Appendix 6.5: Policy codes used for text analysis

We use data from the Comparative Manifesto Project (CMP) (Volkens et al. 2021) to compile our text corpus of those sections of party manifestos in which political parties discuss social policy. The CMP identifies the thematic content of party manifestos using policy codes. We included into our text corpus and then analyzed all sections of party manifestos that are coded as addressing social policy. The specific policy codes we used fall into three broad categories. First, we included "welfare state expansion" (per504) and "welfare state limitation" (per505), which includes policies related to pensions, healthcare, social housing, eldercare and childcare. Second, we included "education expansion" (per506) and "education limitation" (per507). Third, we included "labour policies" (per701, per702) and "corporatism and mixed economy" (per405).

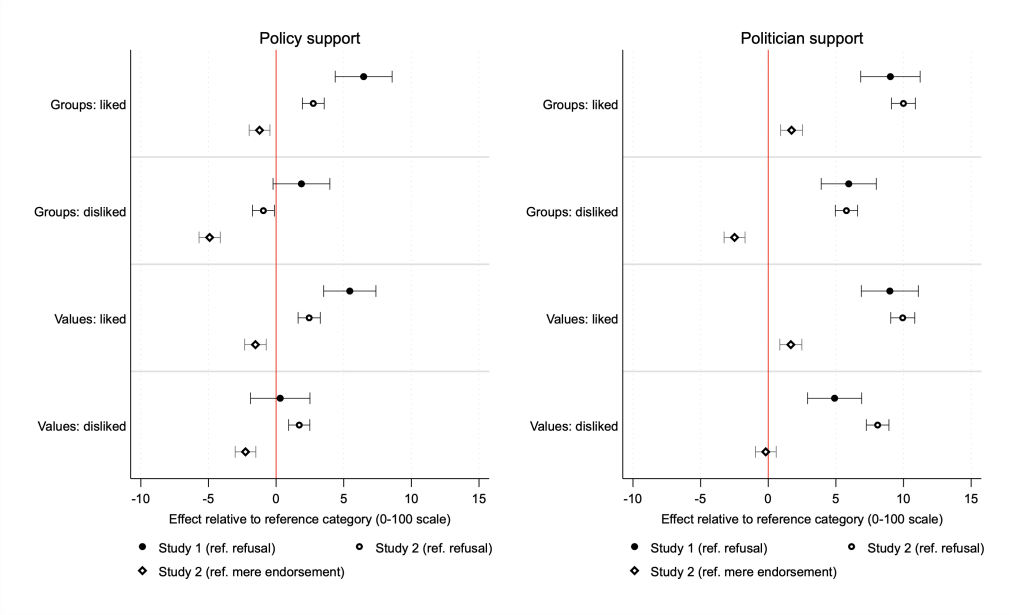
Appendix 7: Robustness Checks

Figure A1: Effects of Combined Group and Value Justifications, Study 1



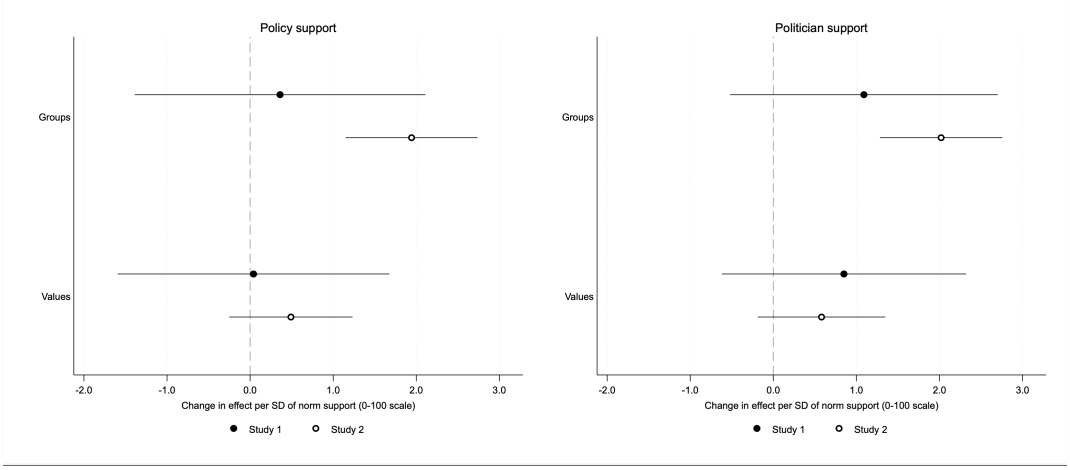
Note: Points report the estimated effects value justifications, group justifications, and justifications invoking both a group and a value, relative to a refusal to justify, with 95% confidence intervals. The combined condition was included in Study 1 only. Estimates use respondent and policy fixed effects, and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Higher values indicate greater support on a 0–100 scale.

Figure A2: Effects of Justifications by Support for the Invoked Norm, Median Split



Note: Points report the estimated effects of group and value justifications, split by whether the respondent rates the invoked group or value above or below the sample median, with 95% confidence intervals. Effects are shown relative to the reference condition. Estimates use respondent and policy fixed effects. Countries are pooled and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. Higher values indicate greater support on a 0–100 scale.

Figure A3: Effects of Justifications by Support for the Invoked Norm, Continuous



Note: Points report the change in the effect of a justification per one standard deviation of support for the invoked group or value, with 95% confidence intervals. Positive values indicate that a justification is more effective when the respondent rates the invoked norm more highly. Support is standardised on the pooled UK and German samples within each study. Estimates use respondent and policy fixed effects. Countries are pooled and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Table A1: Mediation decomposition: Account Satisfaction

	Total (c)	Direct (c')	Indirect (ab)
Study 1, relative to refusal to justify			
Policy support, group	4.10 [2.65, 5.66]	-2.54 [-3.95, -1.05]	6.63 [5.80, 7.44]
Policy support, value	2.83 [1.33, 4.42]	-4.29 [-5.76, -2.71]	7.11 [6.30, 7.89]
Politician evaluation, group	7.40 [5.82, 8.88]	-3.77 [-4.90, -2.68]	11.17 [10.09, 12.39]
Politician evaluation, value	6.90 [5.31, 8.29]	-5.11 [-6.24, -4.09]	12.01 [10.92, 13.09]
Study 2, relative to refusal to justify			
Policy support, group	0.96 [0.29, 1.63]	-6.68 [-7.37, -6.04]	7.63 [7.18, 8.08]
Policy support, value	2.07 [1.40, 2.71]	-5.79 [-6.46, -5.15]	7.86 [7.43, 8.39]
Politician evaluation, group	7.93 [7.24, 8.69]	-3.12 [-3.65, -2.60]	11.05 [10.43, 11.63]
Politician evaluation, value	8.97 [8.27, 9.72]	-2.43 [-2.90, -1.91]	11.41 [10.80, 12.04]
Study 2, relative to mere endorsement			
Policy support, group	-3.06 [-3.64, -2.42]	-5.84 [-6.39, -5.25]	2.78 [2.40, 3.12]
Policy support, value	-1.83 [-2.50, -1.19]	-4.93 [-5.52, -4.37]	3.10 [2.74, 3.44]
Politician evaluation, group	-0.43 [-1.05, 0.23]	-4.17 [-4.68, -3.68]	3.74 [3.28, 4.24]
Politician evaluation, value	0.71 [0.07, 1.33]	-3.48 [-3.96, -2.99]	4.19 [3.70, 4.68]

Note: Point estimates with bias-corrected percentile 95% confidence intervals in brackets, from a cluster bootstrap with respondent-level resampling and 2,000 replications. All models include respondent and policy fixed effects. Outcomes are measured on a 0–100 scale and the mediator is standardised.

Table A2: Mediation decomposition: Perceived Personal Benefit

	Total (c)	Direct (c')	Indirect (ab)
Study 1, relative to refusal to justify			
Policy support, group	2.48 [0.69, 4.18]	1.94 [0.28, 3.49]	0.55 [-0.05, 1.19]
Policy support, value	2.54 [0.83, 4.32]	2.00 [0.46, 3.57]	0.54 [-0.13, 1.20]
Politician evaluation, group	6.15 [4.30, 8.00]	5.77 [4.01, 7.49]	0.38 [-0.02, 0.84]
Politician evaluation, value	6.72 [5.01, 8.52]	6.34 [4.71, 8.13]	0.37 [-0.06, 0.81]
Study 2, relative to refusal to justify			
Policy support, group	0.96 [0.33, 1.60]	0.55 [-0.01, 1.15]	0.40 [0.14, 0.69]
Policy support, value	2.05 [1.43, 2.72]	1.06 [0.48, 1.65]	0.99 [0.74, 1.28]
Politician evaluation, group	7.93 [7.18, 8.64]	7.58 [6.91, 8.23]	0.35 [0.12, 0.58]
Politician evaluation, value	8.99 [8.27, 9.70]	8.11 [7.43, 8.78]	0.88 [0.64, 1.11]
Study 2, relative to mere endorsement			
Policy support, group	-3.07 [-3.68, -2.41]	-2.34 [-2.90, -1.74]	-0.73 [-0.98, -0.47]
Policy support, value	-1.86 [-2.49, -1.21]	-1.72 [-2.28, -1.11]	-0.14 [-0.40, 0.10]
Politician evaluation, group	-0.42 [-1.05, 0.21]	0.22 [-0.39, 0.81]	-0.64 [-0.87, -0.43]
Politician evaluation, value	0.73 [0.08, 1.38]	0.85 [0.25, 1.46]	-0.12 [-0.32, 0.11]

Note: Point estimates with bias-corrected percentile 95% confidence intervals in brackets, from a cluster bootstrap with respondent-level resampling and 2,000 replications. All models include respondent and policy fixed effects. Outcomes are measured on a 0–100 scale and the mediator is standardised. The mediator was administered after both outcome measures; the direct effects in this table are not interpreted.

References (Appendix)

Frimer, Jeremy, Jonathan Haidt, Jesse Graham, Morteza Dehgani, and Reihane Boghrati. 2019. *Moral Foundations Dictionaries for Linguistic Analyses, 2.0.*